

EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

FOR CONVERSATIONAL SKILLS

Kevin Walker



**Learn How To Handle
Crucial Conversations**
In Confrontations Without Being Shy

Emotional Intelligence For Conversation Skills

***Learn How To Handle Crucial Conversations In Confrontations
Without Being Shy***

By Kevin Walker

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Introduction

It is said that a war never has any outcome for the simple reason that the end of a war is marked by a conversation. This may be between the victors and the vanquished or between battle weary adversaries locked in an unending combat. People go to war because millions of years of evolution has primed the human species to either fight to prevail or flee from danger.

Not very different from the other members of the animal kingdom you would say, and you would be right. Modern humans are just a little over 300,000 years old and though communication by way of speaking became a part of human existence quite early, it was by no means the only way that humans came to a decision.

There was far more likelihood for a caveman to use his club to make his point than the power of gentle persuasion. Speaking rationally requires a measure of emotional stability and maturity that many of us still struggle to achieve, thanks to our genetic markers ingrained over the hundreds and thousands of years of primitive human existence.

Coming back to the example of talks following war, these are necessary to make a break from the past and move on to a more constructive future. It would of course be far better that wars and battles were never fought in the first place and nations resolved their problems with rational talk.

The fact that this does not happen in an age where mankind is preparing to travel to Mars tells you something about the difficulty faced in having crucial conversations on account of human emotional instability. That however only serves to accentuate the importance of developing the ability to enhance one's ability to engage in an emotionally mature conversation with the objective of serving one's own best interests.

This ability allows one to find great success in one's personal and business life.

The kind of conversation one conducts decides the responses of those we are seeking to communicate with. We can either be aggressive, insensitive and abrasive or trusting empathetic and rational in our approach, with both

eliciting a commensurate response from the person we are communicating with.

Then there are those people who want to converse well but are shy, diffident and under confident on account of their emotional immaturity. These people, too, will not make much headway or the desired progress, unless they had an epiphany of sorts and learnt to have mature and considered conversations with others.

Reading this book can make readers, who consider themselves in the latter category or others who feel that they need to learn to keep their emotions stable during the course of a conversation, have that very epiphany. The impact that can and will have on people's lives if they genuinely practice what has been prescribed in this book is going to be nothing short of dramatic and even miraculous. You will see success in your personal and business or professional life of the kind that you didn't think was possible. Without much ado, let's find out what it takes to become a conversationalist par excellence, and who is in full command of his or her emotions.

“Highly sensitive people are too often perceived as weaklings or damaged goods. To feel intensely is not a symptom of weakness, it is the trademark of the truly alive and compassionate. It is not the empath who is broken, it is society that has become dysfunctional and emotionally disabled. There is no shame in expressing your authentic feelings. Those who are at times described as being a 'hot mess' or having 'too many issues' are the very fabric of what keeps the dream alive for a more caring, humane world. Never be ashamed to let your tears shine a light on this world.” —**Anthon St. Maarten**

Chapter One:

What Is Emotional Intelligence

Emotional intelligence is a term that one hears a lot these days in the media, at HR (Human Resources) conferences, leadership summits and so on. Everyone agrees that it is a good thing, but not everyone knows what it means exactly.

For all the esoteric and technical sounding terms, emotional intelligence is nothing overly complex – it alludes to nothing more than a person's ability to manage and keep their emotions and also those of the people they come in touch with under control.

As you can imagine, a person who can do this is going to have a calming and stabilizing influence in all situations involving a group of people interacting with each other. A person possessing a decent level of emotional intelligence will always be able to work out his or her relations with the people in their lives-their family members, colleagues and other social groups. To help you understand emotional intelligence, let us break it down into its key parts.

Ability To Be Self-Aware

The ability to be self-aware is an excellent trait to possess. One who is totally aware of where he or she is coming from will be able to moderate their behavior in a way that doesn't allow their predilections to bias their behavior towards other people.

Besides, their perceptive ability will likely make them empathetic towards the view point of the people they interact with, making them temper their responses in light of the knowledge. To exemplify the above, let's consider the following example.

In the first instance, we will take the case of a manager who reaches his office in the morning after a slight tiff with his wife that has left him feeling a little tense. Nothing unusual about that of course, but what we have to watch out for next is how he conducts himself with his colleagues.

He knows that he has a crucial meeting with his team and he can't let his foul mood interfere with what he has to say. So he closes his eyes for a couple of minutes and focuses on the agenda of the meeting and makes a conscious effort to purge any negativity from his mind.

He ends up having a great meeting and the day goes well. When he returns home in the evening, he has forgotten all about his tiff in the morning and in fact takes his wife out for dinner.

Let's take another example. The same manager is having a meeting with his team, on another occasion. One of the star performers of his team has not been performing well lately and it is his job to let the person know that she needs to pull herself together. However, knowing that the erring team member had a break-up with her boyfriend recently, he doesn't broach the subject. He knows that the employee in question is a sincere and very hard worker and will be back to her productive ways in a few days' time, once she is able to put some distance between herself and the recent sad event in her life.

Self-awareness is important because as a very important tool for exercising self-control. A person who has a firm handle on his or her emotional state,

predilections, abilities and resources is a fully self-aware person.

Self-awareness largely has to do with our capacity to analyze who we are inside in terms of thoughts and impulses. So, not only is self-awareness how we see ourselves, but also how we analyze and control our inner most selves.

Self-awareness is not an opinionated or judgmental observation. We acknowledge our human traits for what they are and don't castigate ourselves for the warts or pat ourselves on our backs for all the virtues that we find. The operative word in self-awareness has to be openness about understanding how we react to given situations and storing that useful information in our minds. This will help us form a roadmap for our emotional life.

Self-awareness trains your mind to recognize the kind of behavior problems you will display, when certain situations arise. This lets you devise a strategy to modify and reform such behaviors.

Self-awareness is a major constituent of emotional intelligence. The capability of being able to constantly keep a keen eye on our emotions is the best way to understand ourselves comprehensively and come to terms with who we are and perform a decisive role in consciously managing our emotions and behavior.

The thing about self-aware people is that they tend to act in a forceful and forthright manner, taking the initiative in matters, rather than handle situations in a passive or reactive manner. They are psychologically in top shape and have an upbeat persona.

Because of their nature they are able to have a wider range of experiences that turn them into well-rounded and compassionate individuals. Given how advantageous it is to be self-aware, one would imagine that most people would make a conscious effort to be exactly that.

However, the sad fact is that hardly anyone is self-aware in the manner described here. This is largely on account of people being too caught up with carrying out life's routine functions to really be paying much attention to what is going on inside us and around us.

Apart from this preoccupation with daily activities, we also hamper our ability to be self-aware on account of the various biases we form. For instance, we try to view situations and interpret them in a manner that lets them conform to our preconceived idea about how things should be.

Another example, if you imagine that every Indian you meet will be good with computers and nothing else, you may never imagine that such a person would make a great opera singer, even though he or she has a magnificent singing voice. You will further complicate matters by not even seeking feedback or inputs from others about the matter.

“Your visions will become clear only when you can look into your own heart. Who looks outside, dreams; who looks inside, awakes.”

— **C.G. Jung**

Ability To Exercise Self-Control

Along with the ability to understand your own emotions, you should also possess the ability to keep them in check, when there is a likelihood of their damaging your relations with others. If you happen to be in an emotionally difficult situation, you should think before speaking.

In case you have erred in some way, you should learn to control yourself and not hold others accountable for your actions. This will prevent a bad situation from spiraling into a worse one. A person who possesses the ability to exercise self-control manages to have a positive impact on the people around them.

The manager in the above examples is someone who is able to exercise that kind of self-control in challenging situations, and is therefore able to spread positivity in his interactions with others. The thing about self-control is the fact that we have to be willing to develop it.

The mere intention to do so is not enough. As someone wise once said - "The road to hell is paved with good intentions!" More than intention it's your attitude that helps.

You have got to have a 'can do' attitude. Developing a sense of control empowers one to better deal with stress. Having definite goals helps with working toward achieving self-control.

Taking feedback along the way to see if one has actually traveled some path along the way to achieving self-control. If you are dieting and exercising to lose weight, you have actually got to measure your weight from time to time to see how you are faring.

You should also try and inculcate a "why" rather than a "how" mindset. This will help you learn to postpone mindless instant gratification for a greater long term reward. Self-control really is about adopting a certain pattern of behavior rather than intermittent initiatives.

"What we call our destiny is truly our character and that character can be altered. The knowledge that we are responsible for our actions and attitudes

does not need to be discouraging, because it also means that we are free to change this destiny. One is not in bondage in relation to the past, which has shaped our feelings, to race, inheritance, and background. All this can be altered if we have the courage to examine how it formed us. We can alter the chemistry provided we have the courage to dissect the elements.”

— **Anais Nin**, *The Diary of Anaïs Nin*, Vol. 1: 1931-1934

Level Of Motivation

Motivation could be expressed as an enthusiastic desire to do something. If you approach a task with a high level of motivation, you will likely impart some of your enthusiasm to the people that you are dealing with.

If you are a leader required to show the way, the best way forward is to lead by personal example. In the armed forces, the officers are often trained harder than the men they lead, so that they can inspire confidence in their ability to lead.

If you can show your subordinate, how easy and possibly, how much fun it is to accomplish a task, they will be energized by your level of motivation to give their very best.

If you are able to keep your motivation levels high, regardless of the kind of situation you are facing, the most challenging of tasks won't faze you. You will be the kind of person people will have pleasure interacting with.

That being stated, motivating yourself is often extremely difficult. You want to embark upon a daily regime of jogging, but can hardly drag yourself out of bed, first thing in the morning.

But you can work on enhancing your level of motivation. Just like a muscle gains mass with regular exercise your motivation level can be made to rise with regular practice.

Human nature is wired to take the easiest path when it comes to achieving something. However, this endeavor really requires a lot from a person to work diligently in pursuit of some lofty long-term goal.

But you can succeed if you try to do it incrementally. Taking a typical example of running in a marathon. You cannot start training straight away for an 18 km run. You might want to start with a 5 km run instead. But with practice, you will get there for sure.

Perhaps the greatest example of how a person can keep his or her motivation levels high in the most adverse of circumstances is that of J.K.

Rowling, author of the Harry Potter series of books. Read her speech delivered at the Harvard University, which has been reproduced here, and you will marvel at how she managed to motivate herself when everything seemed to be going horribly wrong for her-

“President Faust, members of the Harvard Corporation and the Board of Overseers, members of the faculty, proud parents, and, above all, graduates.

The first thing I would like to say is ‘thank you.’ Not only has Harvard given me an extraordinary honor, but the weeks of fear and nausea I have endured at the thought of giving this commencement address have made me lose weight. A win-win situation! Now all I have to do is take deep breaths, squint at the red banners and convince myself that I am at the world’s largest Gryffindor reunion.

Delivering a commencement address is a great responsibility; or so I thought until I cast my mind back to my own graduation. The commencement speaker that day was the distinguished British philosopher Baroness Mary Warnock. Reflecting on her speech has helped me enormously in writing this one, because it turns out that I can’t remember a single word she said. This liberating discovery enables me to proceed without any fear that I might inadvertently influence you to abandon promising careers in business, the law or politics for the giddy delights of becoming a gay wizard.

You see? If all you remember in the years to come is the ‘gay wizard’ joke, I’ve come out ahead of Baroness Mary Warnock. Achievable goals: the first step to self-improvement.

Actually, I have wracked my mind and heart for what I ought to say to you today. I have asked myself what I wish I had known at my own graduation, and what important lessons I have learned in the 21 years that have expired between that day and this.

I have come up with two answers. On this wonderful day when we are gathered together to celebrate your academic success, I have decided to talk to you about the benefits of failure. And as you stand on the threshold of what is sometimes called ‘real life’, I want to extol the crucial importance of imagination.

These may seem like quixotic or paradoxical choices, but please bear with me.

Looking back at the 21-year-old that I was at graduation, is a slightly uncomfortable experience for the 42-year-old that she has become. Half my lifetime ago, I was striking an uneasy balance between the ambition I had for myself, and what those closest to me expected of me.

I was convinced that the only thing I wanted to do, ever, was to write novels. However, my parents, both of whom came from impoverished backgrounds and neither of whom had been to college, took the view that my overactive imagination was an amusing personal quirk that would never pay a mortgage, or secure a pension. I know that the irony strikes with the force of a cartoon anvil, now.

So they hoped that I would take a vocational degree; I wanted to study English Literature. A compromise was reached that in retrospect satisfied nobody, and I went off to study Modern Languages. Hardly had my parent's car rounded the corner at the end of the road that I ditched German and scuttled off down the corridor in the direction of the Classics' Department.

I cannot remember telling my parents that I was studying Classics; they might well have found out for the first time on graduation day. Of all the subjects on this planet, I think they would have been hard put to name one less useful than Greek mythology when it came to securing the keys to an executive bathroom.

I would like to make it clear, in parenthesis, that I do not blame my parents for their point of view. There is an expiry date on blaming your parents for steering you in the wrong direction; the moment you are old enough to take the wheel, responsibility lies with you. What is more, I cannot criticize my parents for hoping that I would never experience poverty. They had been poor themselves, and I have since been poor, and I quite agree with them that it is not an ennobling experience. Poverty entails fear, and stress, and sometimes depression; it means a thousand petty humiliations and hardships. Climbing out of poverty by your own efforts, that is indeed something on which to pride yourself, but poverty itself is romanticized only by fools.

What I feared most for myself at your age was not poverty, but failure.

At your age, in spite of a distinct lack of motivation at university, where I had spent far too long in the coffee bar writing stories, and far too little time at lectures, I had a knack for passing examinations, and that, for years, had been the measure of success in my life and that of my peers.

I would never suppose that because you are young, gifted and well educated that you have never known hardship or heartbreak. Talent and intelligence never inoculated anyone against the caprice of the Fates, and I do not for a moment suppose that everyone here has enjoyed an existence of unruffled privilege and contentment.

However, the fact that you are graduating from Harvard suggests that you are not very well-acquainted with failure. You might be driven by a fear of failure quite as much as a desire for success. Indeed, your conception of failure might not be too far from the average person's idea of success, so high have you already flown.

Ultimately, we all have to decide for ourselves what constitutes failure, but the world is quite eager to give you a set of criteria if you let it. So I think it fair to say that by any conventional measure, a mere seven years after my graduation day, I had failed on an epic scale. An exceptionally short-lived marriage had imploded, and I was jobless, a lone parent, and as poor as it is possible to be in modern Britain, without being homeless. The fears that my parents had had for me, and that I had had for myself, had both come to pass, and by every usual standard, I was the biggest failure I knew.

Now, I am not going to stand here and tell you that failure is fun. That period of my life was a dark one, and I had no idea that there was going to be what the press has since represented as a kind of fairy tale resolution. I had no idea then how far the tunnel extended, and for how long a time any light at the end of it was a hope rather than a reality.

So why do I talk about the benefits of failure? Simply because failure meant a stripping away of the inessential. I stopped pretending to myself that I was anything other than what I was, and began to direct all my energy into finishing the only work that mattered to me. Had I really succeeded at anything else, I might never have found the determination to succeed in the

one arena I believed I truly belonged. I was set free, because my greatest fear had been realized, and I was still alive, and I still had a daughter whom I adored, and I had an old typewriter and a big idea. And so rock bottom became the solid foundation on which I rebuilt my life.

You might never fail on the scale I did, but some failure in life is inevitable. It is impossible to live without failing at something, unless you live so cautiously that you might as well not have lived at all – in which case, you fail by default.

Failure gave me an inner security that I had never attained by passing examinations. Failure taught me things about myself that I could have learned no other way. I discovered that I had a strong will, and more discipline than I had suspected; I also found out that I had friends whose value was truly above the price of rubies.

The knowledge that you have emerged wiser and stronger from setbacks means that you are, ever after, secure in your ability to survive. You will never truly know yourself, or the strength of your relationships, until both have been tested by adversity. Such knowledge is a true gift, for all that it is painfully won, and it has been worth more than any qualification I ever earned.

So given a ‘time turner,’ I would tell my 21-year-old self that personal happiness lies in knowing that life is not a check-list of acquisition or achievement. Your qualifications, your CV, are not your life, though you will meet many people of my age and older who confuse the two. Life is difficult, and complicated, and beyond anyone’s total control, and the humility to know that will enable you to survive its vicissitudes.

Now, you might think that I chose my second theme, the importance of imagination, because of the part it played in rebuilding my life, but that is not wholly so. Though I personally will defend the value of bedtime stories to my last gasp, I have learned to value imagination in a much broader sense. Imagination is not only the uniquely human capacity to envision that which is not, and therefore the fount of all invention and innovation. In its arguably most transformative and revelatory capacity, it is the power that enables us to empathize with humans whose experiences we have never shared.

One of the greatest formative experiences of my life preceded Harry Potter, though it informed much of what I subsequently wrote in those books. This revelation came in the form of one of my earliest day jobs. Though I was sloping off to write stories during my lunch hours, I paid the rent in my early 20s by working at the African research department at Amnesty International's headquarters in London.

There in my little office I read hastily scribbled letters smuggled out of totalitarian regimes by men and women who were risking imprisonment to inform the outside world of what was happening to them. I saw photographs of those who had disappeared without trace, sent to Amnesty by their desperate families and friends. I read the testimony of torture victims and saw pictures of their injuries. I opened handwritten, eye-witness accounts of summary trials and executions, of kidnappings and rapes.

Many of my co-workers were ex-political prisoners, people who had been displaced from their homes, or fled into exile, because they had the temerity to speak against their governments. Visitors to our offices included those who had come to give information, or to try and find out what had happened to those they had left behind.

I shall never forget the African torture victim, a young man no older than I was at the time, who had become mentally ill after all he had endured in his homeland. He trembled uncontrollably as he spoke into a video camera about the brutality inflicted upon him. He was a foot taller than I was, and seemed as fragile as a child. I was given the job of escorting him back to the underground station afterwards and this man, whose life had been shattered by cruelty, took my hand with exquisite courtesy, and wished me future happiness.

And as long as I live I shall remember walking along an empty corridor and suddenly hearing, from behind a closed door, a scream of pain and horror such as I have never heard since. The door opened, and the researcher poked out her head and told me to run and make a hot drink for the young man sitting with her. She had just had to give him the news that in retaliation for his own outspokenness against his country's regime, his mother had been seized and executed.

Every day of my working week in my early 20s I was reminded how incredibly fortunate I was, to live in a country with a democratically elected government, where legal representation and a public trial were the rights of everyone.

Every day, I saw more evidence about the evils humankind will inflict on their fellow humans, to gain or maintain power. I began to have nightmares, literal nightmares, about some of the things I saw, heard, and read.

And yet, I also learned more about human goodness at Amnesty International than I had ever known before.

Amnesty mobilises thousands of people who have never been tortured or imprisoned for their beliefs to act on behalf of those who have. The power of human empathy, leading to collective action, saves lives, and frees prisoners. Ordinary people, whose personal well-being and security are assured, join together in huge numbers to save people they do not know, and will never meet. My small participation in that process was one of the most humbling and inspiring experiences of my life.

Unlike any other creature on this planet, humans can learn and understand, without having experienced. They can think themselves into other people's places.

Of course, this is a power, like my brand of fictional magic that is morally neutral. One might use such an ability to manipulate, or control, just as much as to understand or sympathise.

And many prefer not to exercise their imaginations at all. They choose to remain comfortably within the bounds of their own experience, never troubling to wonder how it would feel to have been born other than they are. They can refuse to hear screams or to peer inside cages; they can close their minds and hearts to any suffering that does not touch them personally; they can refuse to know.

I might be tempted to envy people who can live that way, except that I do not think they have any fewer nightmares than I do. Choosing to live in narrow spaces leads to a form of mental agoraphobia, and that brings its

own terrors. I think the wilfully unimaginative see more monsters. They are often more afraid.

What is more, those who choose not to empathise enable real monsters. For without ever committing an act of outright evil ourselves, we collude with it, through our own apathy.

One of the many things I learned at the end of that Classics corridor down which I ventured at the age of 18, in search of something I could not then define, was this, written by the Greek author Plutarch: What we achieve inwardly will change outer reality.

That is an astonishing statement and yet proven a thousand times every day of our lives. It expresses, in part, our inescapable connection with the outside world, the fact that we touch other peoples' lives simply by existing.

But how much more you, Harvard graduates of 2008, are likely to touch other people's lives? Your intelligence, your capacity for hard work, the education you have earned and received, give you unique status, and unique responsibilities. Even your nationality sets you apart. The great majority of you belong to the world's only remaining superpower. The way you vote, the way you live, the way you protest, the pressure you bring to bear on your government, has an impact way beyond your borders. That is your privilege, and your burden.

If you choose to use your status and influence to raise your voice on behalf of those who have no voice; if you choose to identify not only with the powerful, but with the powerless; if you retain the ability to imagine yourself into the lives of those who do not have your advantages, then it will not only be your proud families who celebrate your existence, but thousands and millions of people whose reality you have helped change. We do not need magic to change the world, we carry all the power we need inside ourselves already: we have the power to imagine better.

I am nearly finished. I have one last hope for you, which is something that I already had at 21. The friends with whom I sat on graduation day have been my friends for life. They are my children's godparents, the people to whom I've been able to turn in times of trouble, people who have been kind enough not to sue me when I took their names for Death Eaters. At our

graduation, we were bound by enormous affection, by our shared experience of a time that could never come again, and, of course, by the knowledge that we held certain photographic evidence that would be exceptionally valuable if any of us ran for Prime Minister.

So today, I wish you nothing better than similar friendships. And tomorrow, I hope that even if you remember not a single word of mine, you remember those of Seneca, another of those old Romans I met when I fled down the Classics corridor, in retreat from career ladders, in search of ancient wisdom: As is a tale, so is life: not how long it is, but how good it is, is what matters.

I wish you all very good lives. Thank-you very much.”

Ability To Be Empathetic

The ability to be empathetic towards others is a sign of great emotional maturity. Being totally self-centered to the point of being selfish will not allow anyone to foster great relation with people and thereby negatively impact one's social network.

To be able to make great progress in life, one needs to get other people to support one's cause; but that can only happen on the basis of reciprocity. If you are able to put yourself in the place of others, you will be able to understand the best way to win them over. This works much better than trying to brow beat and intimidate others to get them to cooperate with you. Being empathetic is a sure sign of superior emotional intelligence.

It really is not a herculean task to become empathetic. All that you need to do is to give precedence to someone else's viewpoint for a while, so as to understand where the other person is coming from. You will realize that the other person is not the ogre you thought they were, but just someone reacting to a situation.

The next thing for you to do is to acknowledge that the other person has a valid perspective, even though it may not be the same as yours. At the same time you have got to prioritize what you want in your interaction with another person.

Do you want to build a workable long term relationship based on mutual respect and benefit or are you going to have a take-no-prisoner approach, where it is either your way or the highway.

Listening to the other person with your heart and soul helps, as does trying to understand what the other person is likely to do in a given situation. Say you announce incentives in the shape of shopping vouchers to your favorite clothing store without pausing to think that shopping at a store that you love may not be your team's idea of fun. Maybe they would prefer cash, instead.

“Empathy begins with understanding life from another person's perspective. Nobody has an objective experience of reality. It's all through our own individual prisms.” -Sterling K. Brown

Ability To Socialize

The ability to socialize enables us to effectively communicate our point of view with others and form social relationships with them. If you possess an ability to socialize, whether innate or cultivated, you will be in a position to build rapport with people that will help you form sustainable and useful relationships.

You might often come across people who do not seem to possess the social skills required to build a solid network of friends and professional acquaintances that they can bank on. This may be due to their being too diffident or too aggressive.

Such people are victims of an immature mindset and do not possess the emotional maturity to calibrate and temper their behavior in a manner that benefits them.

You are emotionally intelligent when you are able to manage your feelings in a smart manner. This entails possessing the ability to recognize and manage our emotions in the best possible way.

It also includes the ability to recognize and deal with other people's emotions and developing the wherewithal to be able to conduct oneself in a manner that is conducive to creating and maintaining mutually beneficial relationships.

To summarize, emotional intelligence has to do with the ability of thoroughly understanding and managing the whole slew of human emotions like anger, sadness, joy, fear, grief, love, hatred and stress.

Human beings, it has been stated time and again, are a social species. They need to connect with each other to thrive. That is as true today as it was in the times of early humans.

The reason that humans stole a march over the rest of the species was on account of their superior ability to connect with one another.

Inability to connect or socialize has a negative impact on human beings. It leads to not just truncated development, but also makes one feel inadequate.

Many people find it difficult to connect with others on account of the fact that they are not sufficiently empathetic and hardly spend any time trying to listen to what someone else is trying to tell them and are therefore unable build a rapport.

Another reason some people seem to lack social skills is the fact that they suffer from social anxiety. The very thought of interacting and forging relationships with others makes them break into cold sweat.

There are many reasons of this, all of which originate in their insecurities on account of their past experiences, economic and social backgrounds and a host of other reasons. Working to overcome such issues is not easy, but can be done with practice. Whoever wishes to do well in life will need to fight their demons and overcome their diffidence.

The best way to do that is by embracing yourself and love yourself for who you are. Everyone in the world is unique and offers something exceptional to the world that no one else does. If you approach life like that you will be able to reach out and develop a social network.

You have got to remove the self-limiting beliefs that you have collected over the years in your subconscious mind. Tell yourself to stop believing in all the negativity that you stored in your mind and start over with a clean slate.

What could really help you connect with others would be an attempt to listen to others with an open mind, so that you learn to build two way communication channels with people. At the same time, do project a persona of yours that's you and not a fake one, for that would win you very few friends and make you unpopular. Be assertive, but in a nice way.

Try and be that person who can mirror the persona of the person you are speaking to in terms of a matching of thoughts and world view. This should be done organically in a seamless way so that you are able to establish a rapport.

This is not to be confused with sycophancy, because over here the rapport building arises from a genuine commonality of interest, which is really not such a difficult thing to establish with someone if you are the kind who listens empathetically to others.

If you are able to develop a healthy self-esteem and are totally comfortable in your skin, you will find socializing with others quite easy. Once that happens, there will be a paradigm shift on the way that you live your life for sure.

“We live in an adolescent society, Neverland, where never growing up seems more the norm than the exception. Little boys wearing expensive suits and adult bodies should not be allowed to run big corporations. They shouldn’t be allowed to run governments, armies, religions, small businesses and charities either and just quietly, they make pretty shabby husbands and fathers too. Mankind has become Pankind and whilst ‘lost boys’ abound, there is also an alarming increase in the number of ‘lost girls.’ — **Daniel Prokop**, Leaving Neverland: Why Little Boys Shouldn’t Run Big Corporations.

Chapter Two:

The Impact Of Emotional Intelligence On Conversational Skills

The ability to communicate effectively is a vital skill that helps one lead a successful life in all its important aspects. A person with an excellent ability to communicate fares equally well in both his or her personal and professional or business life.

As touched upon in the last chapter, the ability to communicate well is to a great extent dependent upon the level of a person's emotional ability. This is because only a person possessing the right measure of emotional intelligence will be capable of approaching and tackling important issues that impact one's life with maturity and wisdom.

Take the case of a thirty year old man who has become a father, but has no clue about what that involves. He just can't cope with the fact that the baby might need attending to several times a night or the fact that it will bawl without any apparent reason at the most inopportune times.

On the other hand, there might be someone else who at twenty-five understands exactly what it entails to take care of a baby and takes to changing nappies or quieting a crying baby with the ease of a professional. We can extrapolate the same example to the work place where there will be those who will step up to and assume charge and those who will flounder and blunder all the time.

More than your Intelligence Quotient (IQ), it is often your Emotional Quotient (EQ), which often determines how successful you will be in life. For this reason, we find behavior and motivational experts laying so much store on emotional intelligence, when it comes to teaching people to become better communicators.

How Emotional Intelligence Impacts Communication

Getting a handle on how to be in control of one's emotions is the surest way of improving one's communication skills. If one suffers from an emotional intelligence deficit, one is not able to give a good account of oneself in myriad social situations.

This may make one incapable of things like being a source of strength to the family or giving a good account of oneself in job or performance appraisal interviews. Anybody who lacks emotional intelligence just takes off when faced with situations without filtering and tempering their responses with regard to the tone and tenor of their speech, as well as their body language.

This can jeopardize one's relations with whoever one has a conversation, ie., family, friends, neighbors, colleagues and bosses. This is not a situation any person should be in, if they are serious about making something of their lives.

Improving Emotional Intelligence Positively Impacts Communication

Gaining an understanding of how you respond to social situations from an emotional perspective and how that impacts the way you communicate both verbally and non-verbally, provides you with the ability to temper and filter your responses in different types of social situations. If for instance, you have noticed that you become tense around your boss, you should train yourself to relax your mind in his or her presence, so that you can evaluate what he or she is saying and grant a measured response.

If on the other hand, you couldn't quite place why you always managed to sound like a fool in the presence of your boss, you would continue to be in that sorry situation. Just because you respond to situations at a subconscious level, it does not necessarily mean that you can't course correct. You can do that by first recognizing the source of the problem and then training your mind to address it, as shown in the example above.

By improving and enhancing your emotional intelligence, not only will your voice be heard loud and clearly by those you interact with, you will also be able to motivate and inspire others to look up to you.

For far too long emotional intelligence has been referred to as a 'soft skill' of not much consequence. There is, however, evidence to the contrary, involving people with high emotional achievement having greater chances of achieving success.

As a matter of fact, those who possess higher emotional skills, invariably, improve their so-called 'hard skills' by investing them with creativity. This allows them to leverage their core competencies in a far more creative manner. A software developer who is able to think out of the box on account of his empathetic understanding of his client's requirements is bound to come up with better solutions.

This, in fact, has tremendous implications for the economy of a nation in that emotional intelligence has a positive impact on corporate and

organizational productivity. People with high emotional skills make their conversations count and serve their core interests well.

A number of studies have shown the direct impact emotional intelligence has on factors that contribute to our success. For example, retail managers with high levels of emotional intelligence are known to perform better. Besides, it leads to lower employee attrition and better sales.

In the case of physicians with a better than average emotional quotient (EQ) score, the level of satisfaction reported by their patients is higher.

“Conversation isn't about proving a point; true conversation is about going on a journey with the people you are speaking with.”-**Ricky Maye**

Chapter Three:

Emotional Intelligence And Its Impact On Crucial Conversations

The ability that sets a person apart with regard to his or her capacity to get others to agree with their point of view despite there potentially being a possibility of disagreement or conflict is drawn from a person's emotional intelligence. This enables them to be purposeful decision makers willing to seize the initiative and achieve success in endeavours others may not be too keen to undertake.

Much as we like avoiding difficult conversations that we imagine might lead to conflict, the fact of the matter is that that doing so may actually ultimately lead to the very conflict that you are trying to avoid. If your boss has bypassed you for a promotion that you thought you deserved, you should take it up with him or her and not worry about what he or she might say.

Not having that conversation will deny you the promotion you think you deserve and fuel resentment. So you have got to have that crucial conversation, but do it with maturity in a manner that will not exacerbate, but resolve the situation.

Here's how you might do that:

Plan Your Conversation, But Don't Be Rigid

When you are heading into an important conversation it makes sense to plan what you are going to say, but at the time be prepared to enter the conversation with an open mind. This will enable to view things from a different perspective and enhance your understanding of the situation.

In the above example, for instance, you may plan to insist on asking your boss for a promotion, but do give the latter a chance to explain their position. Suppose he or she suggests that you can have the promotion next year by when you would have gained additional experience and in the meantime accept a healthy raise in salary to compensate for the denied promotion.

It makes sense to be like the palm tree that can bend and flex when faced with a storm than a proud and stout oak, which will be uprooted on account of it not learning to bend with the wind. An emotionally intelligent person will possess the maturity to be nimble, dexterous in their decision making.

Focusing On What You Really Want

When you head into a conversation, which you know may be more than a little challenging, you have to understand that the key thing to achieve is having a dialogue, instead of a total breakdown of communication.

An emotionally intelligent person enters into a potentially difficult conversation with a clear focus about what they want to be the result of the conversation. Now that result invariably will be to achieve a positive outcome and not to teach someone a lesson or showing them their place.

If my boss has denied me a promotion, I will not have a conversation to let him or her know what an idiot they are to deny me my promotion, but to put forth reasons that explain why the company would benefit by promoting me.

So it makes eminent sense for you to mull over the outcome one really wants as a result of the meeting for it to be really successful. Also, have a plan B ready, in case your Plan A fails. Do give your plan A your all though, while you are having that all important conversation, but do have a Plan B all ready to salvage the situation. In the case of the example, we have been using so far, a raise in place of a promotion will constitute the backup Plan B.

Avoiding Conversation Errors

When it comes to carrying out a difficult conversation, it is important that one's chain of thoughts flows in a free and unimpeded way. However, if you approach a conversation in a fearful manner you may either resort to aggression or silence, both of which are not conducive to your cause.

In the example that we used, neither aggression nor silence would make your boss listen to you. So, when preparing to participate in a crucial or serious conversation, go with a clear and lucid mind, so that you can present your case well.

This is where your level of emotional maturity comes into play. Your ability to not let the emotional turmoil you might be feeling inside cloud and bias your thought process is what will help to see you through the forthcoming difficult conversation.

This may be easier said than done, when it comes to crucial conversations, but is something that anybody can achieve with practice. You have got to focus on the bigger picture, and repeatedly tell yourself that the worst time to allow your emotions to get the better of you is a crisis.

For that is when you need to put your best foot forward by taking a well-considered decision. Not doing so means that you are still child-like in your ability to deal with situations arising in the world of adults. This may sound funny, but that is what it is.

Behaving in a fearful and diffident manner or an overly aggressive manner with a challenging situation doesn't behoove an adult. Understanding this basic fact, by repeating it to yourself and trying to do the right thing in difficult situations as they arise in your life, will eventually get you into a situation when emotional intelligence will become your body armor that will get you through the toughest of situations.

When you get to be that good and efficient, you will stop making conversational errors brought on by inadequately developed emotional intelligence.

Engagement through Rapport Building

Remember, it is in your interest to head into a conversation in a friendly and congenial atmosphere. Now that may appear to be extremely difficult when so much rides on the crucial conversation that you are planning to have, but that is exactly when you should possess the emotional intelligence to try and develop a rapport with the person you are seeking to engage with.

Perhaps you could meet at a venue which is a friendly and non-intimidating one like a restaurant or a club, rather than the workplace, if the conversation is work related. Try proactively to build a rapport by listening empathetically to what the other person is saying and try and tune in with their frequency.

Once you have put in place a modicum of mutual understanding, you can engage in expressing what your individual needs and aspirations are, and see if you can find any common ground.

The next step from there would be to try and reach an agreement, if it is only to get to agree on the process to be deployed to find a solution. Finally you can also have a confirmation about the implementation.

If that unfortunately does not happen, you can at the very least agree to disagree for the moment and decide to take another look at an alternative solution that you might look at. The thing is that for any positive conclusion to come out of a conversation, some modicum of rapport has to be established.

Without establishing some rapport you can't even begin to arrive at a solution. So that is something you need to work on, even if your swirl of emotions in a difficult moment makes it impossible for you to do so.

You have got to find a way to somehow connect with your adversary at some point, so as to gain an understanding of what their motivations and pain points are to see if there is any way you can accommodate some of those alongside your own.

Learning To Manage Conflict

Even with the best intentions in order for a civilized and meaningful conversation to arrive at a mutually satisfactory situation, the fact of the matter is that conflict of interests is so deeply entrenched that a resolution through such talks seems well nigh impossible.

Say you are a businessman who suspects that a competitor is instigating your clients into stop buying your products. How do you even begin to start resolving a problem like this through talks?

You have got to first become adept at the art of conflict management to stop situations from spiraling out of control. Here are the steps you can take to achieve that-

- *Don't make the mistake of being totally honest and upfront-*

Real life does not work by boy-scout principles. While by no means advocating immorality or timidity, the fact of the matter is that you can neither belabor the point that you are right nor totally abdicate your right to protest.

You have to be able to strike a balance between stridently conveying your point of view and not taking any action. If for instance you feel that your boss has a habit of taking rudely to you, you definitely mean to bring it to his notice.

The way of doing it is not to accost him and let him know what an inconsiderate boor he is, but to convey diplomatically that you find certain utterances of his offensive.

If you choose the former strategy, you may as well as kiss your career goodbye. By using the latter strategy, you give your boss a chance to reflect upon his or her mistake and possibly take remedial measures.

It is also possible that he or she didn't mean to be rude and didn't realize that they were causing offence. On the other hand, the boss would possibly

correct their ways if they realized that they risk losing an efficient subordinate, if they don't course correct.

At the same time, it is also possible that even with your expressing your discontent in a mild and inoffensive way, your boss doesn't change his or her ways. You would then be within your rights to complain to your boss's superior or even quit the job. But that would always be a last resort. Your first attempt has to be try and resolve a conflict in an amiable way.

- *Don't Just Mechanically Share Your Feelings*

While it is true that you have to convey your side to a person you have a conflict with, you can't do it unthinkingly. You can't tell your boss that you think that he or she is badly brought up going by how he or she talks to you so rudely.

If you unload your feelings like this, and there is not a chance in hell that your boss will ever understand where you are coming from. Instead, couch your feedback in a more acceptable and less alienating language.

Of course, you have to convey the facts of the situation that bother you, but not in a manner that alienates the person you are talking to.

- *Don't come across as to be defending your position too much.*

Remember you are having a conversation to find a solution not prove your point or the fact that you are right. In the above example, you don't want to tell your boss that he or she is wrong and you are right, but that he or she should modify the way they talk to you.

- *Don't blame somebody else for your situation.*

Remember that problems can be resolved not by apportioning blame, but by finding a solution that suits everyone. If your boss appears to be rude, it's possible that he or she talks the same way with others and they don't seem to have a problem.

In that scenario would blaming your boss for the way they talk be a rational thing to do. How about the possibility that you yourself are overly

sensitive? Would you then blame yourself? Allocating blame rouses emotions and does nothing to still them. It is not an emotionally intelligent thing to do.

- *Being afraid of the risks of speaking up*

A crucial conversation is not something that most people approach happily. It invariably accompanies stress. You mull over the possible negative fallout of bringing up something that is not entirely pleasant.

This is an entirely understandable and totally human reaction which one has to overcome with the help of emotional maturity. One has to understand that the risk of not speaking up is far greater with a lot nastier consequences than not speaking up at all.

If for instance you continue to allow your boss to speak to you rudely, you will end up damaging your own self-worth. The thing about communicating with people is that everyone has their own style of communication that best reflects their temperament and predisposition.

For one to be able to communicate successfully with people from markedly different perspectives without creating conflict, one needs to understand, accept and respect the points of views of the people we are dealing with. That is the only way we can have any hope of engaging in a successful and conflict free conversation with them.

“Do not think of knocking out another person's brains because he differs in opinion from you. It would be as rational to knock yourself on the head because you differ from yourself ten years ago.” **Horace Mann**

Chapter Four:

Recognizing Emotional Intelligence In People

It is by now well recognized that the capacity to comprehend and manage or even leverage one's emotions eminently enhances one's chances of finding success in life. That being said, can we recognize signs of emotional intelligence in the behavior of the people we interact with on a day-to-day basis?

Let us look at what are the kind of actions that such people take that marks them out as people with high emotional intelligence.

A Strong Sense Of Self As Well As Social Awareness

People with a highly evolved sense of social awareness possess the ability to identify their emotions and their possible impact on themselves and others around them. They have the ability to reflect and understand what their own strengths and weaknesses are.

They also have a handle on how their current mood is going to impact their thoughts and decision making ability. They also possess the ability to gauge the undercurrents that impact the behavior of others under certain conditions.

The ability to mull over such questions provides them with invaluable insight that can be leveraged to one's advantage.

The Ability To Pause And Step Back

The tendency to rush headlong into decisions without taking a step back to analyze the pros and cons of the decision is a sure sign of emotional immaturity. One should learn to pause and step back to forestall the possibility of making a quick commitment that you will later come to regret.

Like a child who needs to be cautioned about things that are not good for him or her so that they don't end up hurting themselves, so does our mind need to be trained to evaluate and judge before acting upon an impulse.

There is not all that much that separates the human species from other mammals on the planet save the ability to exercise their intellect. That however, as a project, is still evolving and quite a large number of people relapse into the fight or flight mode at the slightest pretext.

The ability to be calm, collected and patient helps one avoid taking permanent decisions with long term implications on the basis of a temporary emotion is an indication of an emotionally evolved person.

The Ability To Control Their Thoughts

This is a corollary of the above point. The process of experiencing emotion cannot really be controlled, as it is hardwired into our system. What you can certainly control is your reactions that result from experiencing these emotions.

This is an ability that emotionally mature persons possess in ample measure. To give an extreme example, you may fall in love with a beautiful actress you see performing a romantic role in a movie. But would you make any attempt to convey your love to her.

You would not because there would be millions like you and you know there is no chance that your overture will be replicated. Yet, so many of us become slaves to our emotions because we don't possess the emotional maturity

The Ability To Learn From Criticism

Not everybody takes to criticism in a constructive or positive manner. Criticism, in fact is an emotional trigger for most people. But the emotionally intelligent people view it as an opportunity to learn, even if the criticism has been conveyed in an unkind manner.

To them, even unjust and uncalled for criticism provides us with an insight into the thought process of the person meting out the criticism. Every time they are criticized, they don't react negatively, but use the occasion as an opportunity to learn something about themselves, if the criticism is fair and about the person handing out the criticism in case it is uncalled for.

They Will Be Genuine

An emotionally mature person will not wear a mask to make up for his or her perceived and real shortcomings. Being genuine does not mean going about offending everyone by saying hurtful things to their face.

On the contrary, it denotes a person who has the courage of their convictions and standing by one's values. This will be something that will not be appreciated by a few, but those will be people who would in any case not be important in one's scheme of things.

Empathy Will Be Their Calling Card

It is quite evident that a person who has the ability to understand and appreciate another's point of view will be able to foster deeper and more meaningful relationships in all walks of life than those who are quick to label people. Empathy doesn't equal acquiescence or surrender of one's own position.

It simply means that you are making an effort to understand and appreciate where the other person is coming from. People who are emotionally immature do not make that connection with others and are consequently not able to form deep and mutually beneficial relationships.

They Are Fulsome In Their Praise of Others

An emotionally mature person instinctively understands human psychology. They know that the best way to build trust with one's peers is by praising them.

An emotionally immature person will be too preoccupied to find anything worth praising in others and will be very stingy with praise. If you have ever met anyone who is the very epitome of charm, wisdom and graciousness watch how he or she operates.

They Provide Feedback Not Criticism

Even while emotionally mature people are able to not just withstand but benefit from criticism, they are careful to not hurt others with their criticism. They know that by providing criticism, even well intentioned, the recipients will likely put up defensive walls.

They would rather provide constructive feedback that the recipient thinks will benefit them. This will both convey the intended message and forestall unnecessary conflict.

They will talk in a most disarming manner and immediately put their audience at ease. How do you think that they are able to do that? By empathizing with the audience and saying things that please them.

They Are Able to Apologize

An emotionally immature person will never apologize as they will likely see it as a sign of defeat or weakness. However, nothing can be farther from the truth, as it takes tremendous courage to apologize to someone.

Apologizing doesn't necessarily mean that you are wrong. Quite often the emotionally intelligent people take it to be an instrument of peace. They know that if they value a relationship, an apology even when they have nothing to apologize for is a very small price to pay in the larger context of things.

They Have The Ability To Forget And Forgive

Carrying a smoldering resentment against someone on account of a perceived wrong or slight is the highest form of emotional immaturity, as it continues to let the person one resents wreak havoc in one's life. The worst part is that the person who one hates with a vengeance doesn't even know that they are such an important part of somebody else's life.

It really is foolhardy to give someone who wronged you more importance than they deserve. An emotionally mature person will be able to forgive and forget and move on to not spend extra time thinking about the person who offended them. For them such people no longer figure in their scheme of things.

They Are Not Commitment Phobic

Not keeping a commitment is not the sign of an emotionally mature person. A person who never keeps his or her word quickly gains the reputation of being unreliable.

This won't do one much good either personally or professionally, but then the emotionally immature people never really are big winners in life. Who for example would like to do business with a businessman who does not turn up for appointments?

Would a father who never keeps his word to attend a baseball match his son is participating in won't really have an ideal relationship with his son. Human relationships thrive only when these are valued.

They Are Helpful

Emotionally intelligent people are helpful. It's not that they are altruistic, but that they realize by helping others they are only building social capital

If people know that they can count on you to stand by them, they will do the same for you. Living in splendid isolation in your own ivory tower is not the sign of an emotionally mature person, but that of an emotionally insecure person or a megalomaniac.

They Are Able To Protect Their Interests

While emotionally intelligent people do not come across as very aggressive and in your face they are not gullible fools either. They are nice, soft and accommodating not because they are suckers waiting to be made fools of, but because they have faith in their own abilities to achieve what they want.

If by being soft and malleable you give the impression of being a work person and you end up getting exploited, then you really are not a fully emotionally aware person. Maudlin sentimentality never really equaled emotional intelligence.

An emotionally intelligent person is usually a strong person, who is quietly confident and will never be emotionally manipulated by someone else for their own benefit.

“What really matters for success, character, happiness and life-long achievements is a definite set of emotional skills – your EQ — not just purely cognitive abilities that are measured by conventional IQ tests.”—
Daniel Goleman

Chapter Five:

A Deeper Understanding Of Emotional Intelligence

It is true that our genetic makeup certainly equips us with emotional markers that have a bearing on our temperament. However, that being stated, our brain circuitry is amenable to modification, which implies that one needn't be a prisoner of destiny.

As children we willy-nilly shape our emotional circuitry in our homes and school, making us quite or hardly emotionally intelligent. However, the fact that you can choose to associate with those who appear to have a firm handle on their emotions and acquire their kind of disposition themselves gives you a strategic advantage that's yours to leverage.

Emotional Intelligence Is Outcome Oriented

Emotional intelligence can be equated with an approach that one takes to a situation which effectively supplants one's primeval inclinations to come up with better consequence for oneself. This is achieved by combining one's innate intellect with one's ability to be emotionally aware to lead to better outcomes.

To that extent the emotional intelligence quotient or EQ is a far better indicator of one's probable success than the traditional IQ or Intelligence Quotient. This is reflected, in fact, that in every case of the measurement of one's ability to perform one's designated role, people with higher levels of emotional intelligence performed consistently better.

Having low emotional intelligence of course does not equal failure, but there certainly is a greater tendency to fail among those who possess a low EQ. This obviously has implication that one would avoid at one's own peril. You have got to up your EQ not only because you want to be nice to others or come across as an affable person, but also because your success in life depends upon it to a very large extent.

Leveraging Emotional Intelligence In The Work Place

The work environment is a challenging one even for the most sorted and emotionally stable of people. After all you need to regularly interact with people you would not necessarily like to associate with given a choice in the matter.

So there will invariably be many occasions of friction, leading to stress and often trauma. There is no physical danger as in the days of early mankind, but the sting of criticism and the hurt caused by a perceived slight can cause an inordinate amount of stress.

It therefor becomes imperative that we learn to temper our response to situations and make things not about how your emotions control you, but how you are in charge of your emotions. You have got to do this by identifying the source of the stress and analyzing closely.

For instance, one's anxiety is more often than not, not the result of your worrying about poor performance, but how others will perceive and react to that. The way to deal with this sort of stress inducing situation is to take on only those assignments that you know you are capable of delivering

If out of bravado or a desperate attempt to prove your worth you wade into an unwanted situation, you only have yourself to blame. On the other hand, you can also try your hardest to deliver the assignment to the best of your ability so that, even if you fail, you would have your honor and dignity intact.

In an alternate scenario there may be a boss who antagonizes his or her subordinated by behaving all-knowing and superior and grievously offending them in the process. An immature boss would not realize that being a boss does not confer any special right to be obnoxious. For them to be an effective leader, they have got to be able to show their subordinates how it is in their own best interest to perform and how the boss would do his or her best to help them achieve the team goal.

Emotional intelligence possibly matters more than general intelligence in that it is critically important factor in achieving success. Unfortunately with all the stress laid in general intelligence in the raising of our young very little attention is paid to teaching kids the value of developing emotional intelligence.

What we need to grasp pretty early on is that we really operate on two levels-the emotional and the rational. For most part the emotional and rational part are in sync, but in turbulent situations the two diverge.

There will be no conflict between emotions and rationality in admiring a beautiful sunset. However if a burly individual were to approach you suddenly in a deserted alley, you might be scared enough to start running away or you might suppress your fear and see if that person merely wants to know the way or the time.

Learning to give precedence to your rational self over your emotional self will stand you in good stead in life. However, this has to be a nuanced approach, considering the fact that you can't kill your emotional side altogether for that would impact your ability to empathize, which would again make you behave irrationally.

The thing is that your emotions form the core of who you are, but you have to learn to temper these so as to prevent them from harming you. Let us draw an analogy with the car your drive.

There's more power under its hood than you are ever going to need. Yet you manage to make optimal use of your car. You drive to work in it and head to the supermarket to pick up groceries. You and your family member also use it to visit friends and family in the town. Sometimes you and your family drive to another town on account of the holidays.

You never start driving your car at 100 miles an hour on a busy thoroughfare, just because your car can do that, because you know you will put you and the other people's life at stake.

It is the same with your emotions; you have got to use them rationally. This is especially true of your workplace, which is likely fraught with consequences to your every action and utterance.

The evidence of the havoc that the lack of emotional intelligence can wreak in our lives is quite evident all around us. Haven't we all come across enough evidence of so many smart people not achieving as much as they should have?

Most of us have come across people who are brilliant at the technical stuff, but abysmal when it comes to managing people or working as part of a team. It really doesn't have to be this way, as these brilliant minds can easily be made to rationally understand how their inability to rein in their emotions is harming them.

Once you realize that your inability to process and temper your emotions is a huge stumbling block in your success you will be motivated to do something about it. Of course changing the way you are naturally inclined to behave takes time, patience and at times professional help.

But the good news is that change you can. The human brain is a wonderful organ that can be trained to serve your interests. You can therefore make a conscious effort to enhance your emotional maturity and actually be able to achieve it.

Physiology Of Emotional Intelligence

There is no doubting the fact that our decision making is largely an outcome of our emotional state. That is how the brain is wired on account of evolutionary reasons. Early humans lived a life of constant danger and emotions were like a defense mechanism that helped them survive.

But then times changed, and many emotions that were useful back then, in modern times, need to be kept in check for our own good. This is where emotional intelligence comes in. Emotional intelligence, which is largely understood as EQ or emotional intelligence quotient, is responsible for exercising control over our amygdala as well as other parts of the brain that are responsible for creating emotions like anxiety, nervousness, fear, hurt, rejection and other such feelings.

What happens when we descend into this kind of thought process is the fact that we start behaving in an irrational manner, consequently negatively impacting our intelligence quotient (IQ) level as well. People with well-developed emotional intelligence levels do not allow their circumstances to dictate their actions.

To them, all extraneous influences exerted by their family, friends, colleagues, or anyone else will not shake their belief in the rightness of their decisions. Take the case of two students preparing for an important examination.

While one of them is focused on acing his or her exams to gain admission in a reputed college, the other one prevaricates and doesn't prepare hard enough because he or she believes his or her friends and some neighbors who tell them that the exam is too tough to seriously be aced and he or she would be lucky to even pass.

So that person gives up his or her dream of joining a prestigious college and is more or less resigned to start working as an apprentice once the results are announced. This, when this person has made no attempt to understand his or her own aptitude and has instead disrespected his or her own ambition.

Emotional intelligence therefore has to do with not just understanding and managing your emotions, but also those of the ones you interact with. In the above example, the person who is discouraged by others should have had the emotional intelligence to understand that those who proffered him or her the advice most likely did it out of envy or sheer ignorance.

The lack or deficiency of emotional intelligence condemns us to a life of anxiety, fear and nervousness. It makes us avoid taking risks and not take up anything that challenges in some way thereby keeping us from fulfilling our true potential in all areas of our life.

This fact is comprehensively backed by research which suggests that low emotional intelligence negatively impacts one's IQ as well as one's performance in important aspects of one's life. The good news is that emotional intelligence needn't remain static and can, in turn, lead to higher professional and personal success.

“If you want maximal productivity and if you want work that gets the best results, you want the people doing that work to be in the optimal brain state for the work. You are a person who can evict them from the zone of optimal performance by slothfully handling your own interactions with them. So it's up to you to take responsibility for your impact on their ability to work at their best”. —**Daniel Goleman**

Chapter Six:

The Dynamics Of Emotional Intelligence

The most important thing to understand about emotional intelligence is the fact that it is a force that we can use either for our betterment or to our detriment. There are obviously things that you need to do to make it work the right way for you.

You need to learn to work with your most powerful emotions to make them work as your allies. If for instance you strongly feel that you are the most deserving member of your team for a promotion, you need to use your passion as a positive force to help you achieve your goal and not smolder and fester with unfulfilled ambition.

You can do so by asking yourself the right questions about what causes you to stumble in your growth. Maybe your capacity to process your emotions and get to understand your own desires and how you can help achieve them will help. This is nothing but self-awareness. Once you are self-aware, you have achieved the first step towards enhancing your emotional intelligence.

Learning to achieve self-control, notwithstanding how difficult this act, is one of the most important aspects of achieving emotional maturity. Improving this one ability has the most profound impact upon your emotional maturity and you really need to figure out, how to achieve it.

Getting to understand how the human brain functions and how you can take its help to form healthy emotional habits is the way to go. Again using feedback, whether positive or negative to help improve that way that one conducts oneself is also a way to enhance your emotional maturity.

At the same time, you need to be able to provide your feedback to others in an empathetic manner. Empathy itself can be a double-edged tool as if you are emotionally vulnerable; it can turn you into a self-effacing kind of person.

The part of the human brain that processes emotions evolved earlier than the thinking and rational part. Emotional intelligence is the ability to

leverage the capabilities of the evolutionary younger part of the brain-the cerebral cortex in conjunction with the emotional part.

We no longer need to depend upon our primeval instincts to deal with life - no one needs to hunt wild animals for survival like early humans anymore, and to that extent our primeval emotions are no longer critical to our survival. We instead need to leverage that thinking part of our brain to do well at our jobs and make money.

We base almost all of our decisions based upon our feelings and emotions. Learning how to manage them to our best advantage, makes our personal and professional lives that much better.

What is great news is the fact that emotional intelligence is not something that one is naturally endowed with, but can be learned and acquired. An emotionally intelligent person can be identified by their demeanor.

They will be open to new ideas and experience, express emotions that are commensurate to the situation and find it quite easy to get along with people and form friendships and useful associations. They will seemingly be able to handle stressful situations well, have a pretty accurate assessment of their own capabilities and that of others.

Saying no, where required would come easy to them, as would the ability to accept constructive criticism. They would also possess the ability to take calculated risks.

The modern era has been characterized by an inordinate amount of stress being laid upon acquiring information and rational thinking. The digital era has caused an information overload, which does not really augur well for the emotional health of people who do not know what to do with all the information that they possess.

While everybody possesses a wonderful organ like the human brain, very few really know how to use it the right way. To be able to consciously leverage one's thoughts in a focused manner and regulate one's emotions to serve one's best purposes is not something that seems to be happening a lot, judging by the spate of mental health problems experienced by large sections of the world.

Not enough attention has been devoted to the important issue of developing people's emotional intelligence alongside their other faculties. As a matter of fact there is scientific research available showing that 'regular' intelligence induced responses are responsible for less than 20% of our life's achievements and emotional intelligence is responsible for 80% of that number.

Therefore, it is imperative that parents, teachers and society, as a whole, needs to get their act together with regard to training children to evolve their emotional intelligence. This will better equip them to deal with life when they grow up and achieve far more success and happiness than they would by merely honing their general intelligence and skills.

The ability to sensibly express our emotions is very important, as is the ability to understand and act upon the emotions of others. You wouldn't want to be that insensitive brute who doesn't seem to know when his or her spouse is upset, or a friend is distressed about something.

You could say that emotional intelligence has four components:

- The first one has to do with perceiving emotions of others, not just by what they say, but by what they don't say as well. This is an ability that you can improve upon with keen observation and practice.

What you have got to understand here is that while the potential for being emotionally intelligent might be present in everyone, the ability needs to be built up by observation and trial and error.

Take the case of animals. While their instinct might tell them to take care of their young, they don't possess the emotional intelligence of humans to love and care for them for life.

Once their progeny are grown up, they are like any other member of their species with whom they compete, fight and even mate. The more human develop their emotional intelligence the higher they evolve as living organisms.

- The next step involves reasoning with the help of emotions. Our emotions let us prioritize our actions. If a cousin of yours makes it to a

coveted medical school, you may feel a competitive urge to do the same. Of course the emotionally intelligent thing to do would be to take the steps to help achieve that. An emotionally unstable person, on the other hand, might just end up wallowing in jealousy.

- Interpreting emotions is the next stage. You do that right and the action that you take to deal with it will be the right one. If your spouse seems to be unreasonably angry with you, instead of getting into how she or he is so wrong in behaving thusly, try to analyze the reason.

Did you say anything that inadvertently annoyed her, or did she possibly have a rough day at the office?

- Lastly you need to know how to leverage your emotions to your best advantage. This involves managing and regulating your own emotions so as to make them commensurate with the situation at hand. This also has to do with developing a firm understanding of the emotions when dealing or negotiating for something, so as to be able to come up with bespoke approaches at different times to help get the best outcome for the interaction.

Once you understand the dynamics of emotions - yours and those of others - you will find that your relationships with people will improve considerably. These people could be your family, your boss, your subordinated and anybody else who matters to your life.

Getting a handle on the dynamics of emotion will make you a better a parent, spouse, boss, subordinate, leader, neighbor and so on. If you are already extremely intelligent, well qualified and trained, being emotionally intelligent will take you right to the top.

“If your emotional abilities aren't in hand, if you don't have self-awareness, if you are not able to manage your distressing emotions, if you can't have empathy and have effective relationships, then no matter how smart you are, you are not going to get very far.” -Daniel Goleman

Chapter Seven:

Learning To Converse Right

There is an old adage which goes something like sticks and stones *may break my bones, but words won't hurt me*. Let me take the statement out of the context in which it was meant (don't let people's words demoralize you) and categorically state that this is a fallacious statement.

Words are a tremendously powerful phenomenon in that they represent us and what we stand for to the world. They are therefore profoundly important for us and, in fact, determine our very destiny.

A conversation not carried out the right way can cause us a great deal of unavoidable trouble. A conversation when carried out the right way helps us connect with others in a manner that can be supremely beneficial to us, in that it creates social capital for us. Yet the importance of speaking the right words at the right time, is barely understood by individuals and organizations. Badly carried out conversation can lead to consequences like a lack of trust and a possible emergence of deceit and treachery. Your conversation, in fact, acts as a trigger for a host of reactions among the people we are conversing with.

From eliciting loyalty and trust to inciting disgust and disdain among others, a conversation can make or break your fortune. For this reason, it is so important you acquired the ability to converse in an intelligent and emotionally mature fashion.

In marketing parlance you often hear stuff about elevator pitches. An elevator pitch is something that lets you explain and sell the salient features of a concept, product or service to somebody in the time it takes to complete an elevator ride.

Apparently, the ability to make an elevator pitch can swing deals worth millions of dollars in a matter of minutes. With so much riding on the outcomes of a conversation lasting a couple of minutes, you can imagine the premium the marketers would be ready to pay to someone adept at creating them.

Every conversation has a certain effect upon the human brain. Some conversation makes the listener freeze, while others might bring them alive. By knowing what type of conversation brings about the latter kind of result one could become a past master at motivating individuals and organization to achieve super success.

Considering the almost life altering impact our words might have it makes eminent sense to develop a framework to develop deep relationships and an overall culture. It is not just the person that we have a conversation with that gets impacted, it is also our own neurochemistry that gets impacted.

Conversations can stimulate the brain to produce hormones and neurotransmitters that can, in turn, stimulate the creation of newer nerve pathways and permanently modify one's body chemistry for the better. Additionally conversations empower us to convey our deepest thoughts, desires and feelings, enabling us to firm up our relationships and associations.

A marriage proposal is an ideal example of leveraging conversation in an intelligent manner, so as to win oneself a life partner. For want of a better description one could say that conversation is like clothing for our desires, aspiration and hopes, dressed in such a way, making it possible to convey our message in the best way to the right people.

Conversation can help us shape reality in the image we desire. If we are, for example told that our job skills are redundant and perhaps we should think of reskilling, we might use the pretext to start the business we were planning to start, but somehow kept putting it off.

As a matter of fact, every conversation that we have could lead to some form of transformation big or small. Therefore it is important that we have a blueprint about the way we can leverage conversations to our advantage.

Now how do we do that? We have got to remember that we approach situations with a perspective that is distinct and different from what someone else might have about the same situation.

Therefore what we think is the best course of action in a given situation may not be the best course of action in someone else's opinion. If we

persist in imagining that everybody has the same world view as we do, we will open the door for some serious conflict and strife.

The way out of this is again through conversation where we try to get divergent perspectives to come to a meeting point. By becoming an emotionally mature conversationalist, you are able to engage in ongoing dialog with people with perspectives that are very different from yours.

This lets us eventually get on the same page with others, enabling one to collaborate and achieve goals together.

Converting Opponents To Collaborators

If you are a sales person you will often have come across the feeling that a sales call is something of a gladiatorial contest. This may be on account of the fact that while you are trying your best to educate your prospective customer about your product, they in turn are convinced that you are trying to force a sale, whether they want it or not and will therefore make every attempt to ward off your attempts to seal the deal.

To get around this instead of educating the prospect about your product or service, you first check with them, if you could be of any assistance to them with regard to any issues they may be having about the product or service that you sell.

You don't even have to talk about your brand and its attributes to start with. Just try and find out the points that bother them. Are they sick of their diesel car what with its high cost of maintenance, its sluggish performance and environmental issues? Have they heard of the new age environmental friendly cars that give great performance and have extended battery power?

This is a far better approach to start off with than dazzle them with battery specs, acceleration and like stuff.

Conversing Under Stress

Any conversation can turn crucial without warning. Say you are waiting to catch a flight at an airport and a well-dressed person sitting next to you strikes up a conversation. The two of you hit it off; you soon find out that the person with whom you are chatting is the chairman of the company you always wanted to work for. Suddenly, you have a stake in this conversation, as it has become crucial from a career point of view.

A vital conversation can cause stress to a person and their ability to cope with it, allowing for us to give a good account of ourselves – it all depends on our level of emotional maturity. It makes sense to train oneself to identify these signs of stress, so that we can make a considered effort to calm and soothe ourselves and develop the ability to converse in a measured and attuned manner when it matters the most.

If one develops the ability to understand that way one typically converses under stress, one will be able to take corrective action and make the necessary adjustments with regard to the kind of behaviors that harms our cause.

If we are able to detect and remedy signs of stress during a crucial conversation, we can do the same for the people with whom we are having the crucial conversation. We can then alter our behavior in a manner that the other person feels at ease, thereby bringing harmony to a conversation and increasing the chances of a successful conclusion.

Willingness To Change Your Style Of Conversation

A conversation, especially a crucial one, is nothing if not a dynamic phenomenon. A skillful conversationalist, while making some preparation before entering a crucial conversation to make it flow in a certain way will be open to changing his or her style of conversation, if the situation so requires.

If the way in which your conversation is flowing is clearly not working, it's perhaps time to adopt a different approach. The trick, however, lies in being able to do so under conditions of stress.

This is something that requires lots of practice, but the good news is that it can be done. The ability to change your style of conversation is very effective in obtaining a successful conclusion to a conversation.

Whenever a conversation ends badly and you wish that you had handled it right, that is exactly what the willingness and ability to change your style of conversation achieves.

Understanding The Structure Of A Difficult Conversation

If you ever observe the structure of the difficult or tough conversations that you have had, you will notice great overall similarities. This may not be very apparent when you are in the throes of that kind of a conversation, but once you analyze its structure in retrospect you will come to the same realization.

For instance, it is not just what is said, but what is unsaid that must be given special attention. For instance, somebody might say in words that they agree with you, but their tenor and body language could convey just the opposite of that.

The second thing to note is that we misunderstand and misinterpret the intention of the person we are having the difficult conversation with. Say, for instance, we find the other person talking loudly and aggressively and assume that he or she is trying to intimidate us.

The fact of the matter might actually be that the other person is intimidated by you and their loud talk and aggression is indicative of their nervousness and not any desire to intimidate you. People's intentions are difficult to read and in trying to second-guess them, we often make mistakes of judgment.

Another common feature of a difficult conversation is the desire to fix or apportion blame. If you didn't manage to land a coveted contract, you and your team members would want to deflect blame from yourselves to someone else. The problem with apportioning blame is that it only produces strife and disagreement and no solution. Whereas the focus should be on identifying the real reasons behind the failure and trying to fix them instead of blaming, as it leads to unpleasantness and loss of focus.

Dealing With Our Emotions

Difficult conversations are not to be studied only from the point of view of the outcome. They are also to be understood from the point of view of the emotions that they invoke in a person.

It is perhaps inevitable that emotions will be stirred during the course of a conversation. However, what is important is how we deal or grapple with those emotions. When strong feelings are stirred it is often quite a tall order to stay reasonable.

One is faced with a dilemma about whether one should share one's core concerns or keep those suppressed to avoid a possible blow back. The latter course of action is escapist and overlooks the fact that difficult conversations are, in fact, driven by feelings.

At the same time, the understanding and managing of feelings is quite a difficult thing to achieve for any human being. Talking about feelings is so fraught and an extremely tough thing to manage and yet it needs to be done.

The good news is that one can with practice learn to express one's feelings and get progressively better. Sure, there may be times when you don't express your feelings in order to avoid grave trouble, but that cannot be your default template for every situation.

You have to learn to find a way to convey what you feel about a situation and how you would like it to be resolved. If you don't learn to do that, you will become an eternal pushover that everyone and at everybody's mercy.

The advantages of being able to converse well are tremendous and have a bearing on every aspect of one's life. The ability to speak well creates opportunity. Most career options are dependent upon people's ability to motivate others to give their best to the task at hand, or pitch an organization's products or services to buyers in an emphatic manner.

All of this requires the arousal of passion and your persuasion skills to motivate your team, colleagues or clients to believe in your word and do

your bidding. Moreover, when you talk about being empathetic towards the others, how can you possibly do that without engaging in a conversation?

When we talk about being emotionally healthy, letting off steam and venting our feelings is an important thing to do. The best way of venting one's feelings is by way of talking about them.

This allows one to cool down and also analyze one's behavior and what causes it. Besides, it also lets others understand the red lines they must never cross when interacting with you.

If you speak, you will be heard, which you will agree is a very good thing. Especially, if you are good at relating a story, you will have people eating out of your hand. Speaking can really achieve great great results. It has the ability to inform, improve and transform.

“People who are skilled at dialogue do their best to make it safe for everyone to add their meaning to the shared pool—even ideas that at first glance appear controversial, wrong, or at odds with their own beliefs. Now, obviously they don't agree with every idea; they simply do their best to ensure that all ideas find their way into the open.” — **Kerry Patterson**, *Crucial Conversations: Tools for Talking When Stakes Are High*

Chapter Eight: Road Map For Handling A Critical Conversation

Perhaps the finest example of handling a critical conversation in an emphatically impactful manner comes from none other than the Bard himself. In his play Julius Caesar, Marc Antony, the recently assassinated Caesar's friend and supporter, is allowed a final courtesy of addressing a restive and hostile crowd on behalf of Caesar by Brutus the leader of the band of conspirators who carried out the assassination.

Brutus has spoken to the crowd first and convinced them that assassinating Caesar was in the interest of Rome and its citizens as Caesar had grown too ambitious and put his own interests before that of Rome. So Marc Antony had his task cut out for him.

He has to try and persuade a partisan and hostile crowd about the fact that Caesar was not the villain that he had been painted by the conspirators and in fact that his heart bled for Rome. He had to do this even while surrounded by his friend Caesar's sworn enemies.

He began his speech with humility and then deftly and cleverly weaved in a narrative of a wronged Caesar who needed to be avenged. It is the stuff of legends. At the end of his masterly speech, the crowd was ready to rise and mutiny against Brutus and the other conspirators.

"Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears; I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him. The evil that men do lives after them; The good is often interred with their bones; So let it be with Caesar. The noble Brutus hath told you Caesar was ambitious:

If it were so, it was a grievous fault, And grievously hath Caesar answer'd it. Here, under leave of Brutus and the rest – For Brutus is an honourable man; so are they all, all honourable men—

Come I to speak at Caesar's funeral.

He was my friend, faithful and just to me:
But Brutus says he was ambitious;
And Brutus is an honourable man.
He hath brought many captives home to Rome
Whose ransoms did the general coffers fill:
Did this in Caesar seem ambitious?
When that the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept:
Ambition should be made of sterner stuff:
Yet Brutus says he was ambitious;
And Brutus is an honourable man.
You all did see that on the Lupercal
I thrice presented him a kingly crown,
Which he did thrice refuse: was this ambition?
Yet Brutus says he was ambitious;
And, sure, he is an honourable man.
I speak not to disprove what Brutus spoke,
But here I am to speak what I do know.
You all did love him once, not without cause:
What cause withholds you then, to mourn for him?
O judgment! thou art fled to brutish beasts,
And men have lost their reason. Bear with me;
My heart is in the coffin there with Caesar,

And I must pause till it come back to me.”

After a dramatic and meaningful pause Antony resumed his speech and sensing the change in mood of the crowd decided to go all out in raising passions among them.

“But yesterday the word of Caesar might have stood against the world; now lies he there. And none so poor to do him reverence. O masters, if I were disposed to stir your hearts and minds to mutiny and rage, I should do Brutus wrong and Cassius wrong, who you all know are honourable men:

I will not do them wrong. I rather choose to wrong the dead, to wrong myself and you than wrong such honourable men. But here’s a parchment with the seal of Caesar. I found it in his closet, ’tis his will:

Let but the commons hear this testament-

Which pardon me, I do not mean to read- And they would go and kiss dead Caesar’s wounds and dip their napkins in his sacred blood, yea, beg a hair of him for memory, and dying, mention it within their wills, bequeathing it as a rich legacy unto their issue.”

Naturally, the crowd became quite restive on hearing this and began to clamor that the will be read. Antony is of course more than happy to play up their impatience-

“Have patience, gentle friends I must not read it; It is not meat you know how Caesar loved you. You are not wood, you are not stones, but men; and being men, bearing the will of Caesar, it will make you mad: ’Tis good you know not that you are his heirs: For, if you should, O, what would come of it!”

This is just the cue for the crowd to demand that the will be read forthwith and Marc Antony was ready to oblige them, but pretended to be hesitant-

“Will you be patient? Will you stay awhile? I have o’shot myself to tell you of it: I fear I wronged the honourable men whose daggers have stabb’d Caesar; I do fear it.”

By now the crowd is belligerent and denounced Brutus and the conspirators as villains and traitors.

Antony then seemed to relent-

“You will compel me, then, to read the will? Then make a ring about the corpse of Caesar, and let me show you him that made the will. Shall I descend? And will you give me leave?”

He then proceeded to deliver the culmination of his speech where he alluded to the brutality of the murder of Caesar by his trusted friend Brutus. He also let it be known that since he is no orator (the irony!) like Brutus is, he can hardly incite them to wreak vengeance on the perpetrators of this ghastly crime.

This makes the crowd hell-bent upon violence and destruction and they prepare to go after the traitors and kill them. To add fuel to the already raging fire Antony now let the people know that Caesar had bequeathed them and to their heirs his private garden and orchards located on one side of the River Tiber.

Once Antony manages to win over the support of his masses thanks to his superb oratory, the conspirators' fortunes suffer a dramatic reversal and they all eventually get killed. These speeches by Marc Antony are a much heralded example of how one can keep calm, composed and focused, even while in the middle of an extraordinary crisis and turn a situation of extreme hostility into one which is in one's own favor.

Antony displayed more emotional maturity than Brutus and the conspirators who allow him to speak to the common crowd, even though that was a risky thing to do. By displaying humility toward the conspirators, Antony warded off any danger to himself.

He then very skillfully took control of the immature and emotionally volatile crowd by proving to them that far from being a ruthless and ambitious tyrant Caesar was a nice and generous man who was the great benefactor of the masses.

The reason Antony did so well in swaying the peoples' will was to get in sync with them and their desires. It is his emotional maturity and

intelligence that is clearly leagues ahead of his contemporaries that makes him emerge a clear winner.

What you have got to understand is that it is not the fact that Brutus and the conspirators were wrong and Antony was right that swayed the crowd so. It was the fact that Antony made it appear so.

That is the thing about conversations, they can change the very nature of a discourse by the shape they take and the truth that they convey. Why do you think that so much importance is placed upon presidential debates in the U.S.? It is the fact that people like to hear from the candidates themselves and likely decide whether they trust a candidate to become President on the basis of how they emotionally react to hearing and watching the person than any number of stats and figures presented by the expert.

The candidates who follow a road map in the way they approach the Presidential debates are the ones who win the battle of perception in the voters' mind. Now, this is as true of you and me as well and not just for presidents and prime ministers.

We all have our critical conversations to make in life. It may be one with your spouse about an unraveling relationship or it may be about a troublesome neighbor who dumps his or her trash in your backyard. It could, of course, be career related where you want to let your boss know that you feel that you are grossly underpaid and unless you are given a raise, you will have to accept one of the many offers that rival companies have often made to you.

Stage 1

You have come to the conclusion that you need to have a critical conversation for you to resolve a pressing issue. It is not important that you think of having that conversation or another person suggested that you have one - what is important is the fact that you agree that the conversation should take place.

This is truth of any situation of significance like the ones described above. Agreeing to have a critical conversation is the first big step as you have acknowledged that things will get better or resolved only after the critical

conversation has taken place. Taking this decision is an important first step because people, as a rule, tend to avoid contentious situations.

Only after you are convinced of participating in a critical conversation will you be able to deal with it. You may of course be forced have to have a crucial conversation like in the case of your being summoned by the court, but the importance of accepting the inevitability and indeed necessity of going through with it will put you in the right frame of mind to make the most of it.

Stage 2

Once you are ready to take part in a critical conversation, you can start paying attention to what your stand is going to be. You need to be sure as to what it is that you are defending.

It really depends upon what is at stake. In the case of the neighbor dumping garbage in your backyard, your stance could be one of warning the neighbor of the legal consequences of his or her behavior, and you would be perfectly justified.

On the other hand, you might want to explain the situation to your neighbor, an old woman living alone, convincing her to take the trouble to keep the garbage outside the main gate of her home, so that it can be taken away by the garbage truck. Perhaps she could be told that she faces a fine by the authorities if she didn't do that if they found out. Besides, it would be good for her own health if she maintained hygiene in her home and neighborhood.

Stage 3

Before you take on the onerous responsibility of taking a principled stand with someone else, you should analyze your own position and see if it is possible that you might need to make some course correction of your own. If you want to talk to a colleague about his or her bad habit of appropriating credit for your achievements, be absolutely sure that that is indeed the case, or you will cut a very sorry figure if you are proved wrong later.

Once you are sure that you are justified about the stand that you are going to take, you should go ahead and press ahead with having that critical and

candid conversation.

Stage 4

Prepare and go. Often, we are so stressed just before a critical conversation is about to take place that we are not able to put forth our best arguments. In order for you to forestall this, you should go over all the points that need to be addressed several times, so that there is no possibility of your forgetting any of them.

You have to make the conversation count and should therefore make a conscious effort to focus on your main points and get them addressed.

Stage 5

Don't be needlessly combative and neither should you be submissive. Approach the conversation with confidence and poise. Start talking on a pleasant note. Let the other person believe that you are not going to exclusively push your agenda, but will try and arrive at a consensus.

However, not all critical conversations can begin on an amiable note. Say you want to convey to your spouse that you want to end the marriage. That cannot be easy or pleasant, but try to keep it that way. Being able to manage that is a measure of your emotional maturity.

Stage 6

The ability to be flexible and to be able to think on your feet is something that will stand you in good stead when you are carrying out a critical conversation. While it is great to go prepared for an important discussion, you need to understand that you are going to be interacting with a live human being and not a computer program.

You can temper your conversation according to the way that the situation evolves. Above all you have to always remember that more than anything else it is emotions that rule human behavior.

In the example of someone trying to tell their spouse about their decision to end the marriage, it is possible that the other person might become distraught at the very prospect of what you are contemplating. You can't

just be heartless and press on. That would mess up things for you and lead to a nasty separation. Maybe, you can drop the topic of conversation for the time being and prefer to take it up at another time.

Alternatively, as you start talking to your spouse, you yourself have a change of heart and feel that breaking up would be a mistake. You can always change your plan and not go ahead with the task of telling your spouse about the plan.

People change, situations change and circumstances change. You should possess the maturity to adjust your stance accordingly.

At the end of the day, it is your emotional intelligence that saves the day for you. Life will require you to have these critical conversations all the time. It is for you to step up to the plate and deal with them.

This poem by the great writer and poet Rudyard Kipling sums up what it is to be emotionally mature:

“If you can keep your head when all about you are losing theirs and blaming it on you,

If you can trust yourself when all men doubt you,

But make allowance for their doubting too,

If you can wait and not be tired by waiting,

Or being lied about, don’t deal in lies,

Or being hated, don’t give way to hating,

And yet don’t look too good, nor talk too wise,

If you can dream—and not make dreams your master,

If you can think—and not make thoughts your aim,

If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster

And treat those two impostors just the same,

If you can bear to hear the truth you've spoken
Twisted by knaves to make a trap for fools,
Or watch the things you gave your life to, broken,
And stoop and build 'em up with worn-out tools
If you can make one heap of all your winnings
And risk it on one turn of pitch-and-toss,
And lose, and start again at your beginnings
And never breathe a word about your loss;
If you can force your heart and nerve and sinew
To serve your turn long after they are gone,
And so hold on when there is nothing in you
Except the Will which says to them: 'Hold on!'
If you can talk with crowds and keep your virtue,
Or walk with Kings—nor lose the common touch,
If neither foes nor loving friends can hurt you,
If all men count with you, but none too much,
If you can fill the unforgiving minute
With sixty seconds' worth of distance run,
Yours is the Earth and everything that's in it,
And—which is more—you'll be a Man, my son!"

Most of the seemingly intractable conflicts in the world stem from an inability to engage in a critical conversation. The Arabs and Israelis for example could certainly have peace amongst themselves if they learnt how to conduct critical conversations with each other in the manner that these should be carried out-with empathy, understanding and compromise.

North Korea recently started having that critical conversation with South Korea and the U.S. If these conversations continue down the path, a nearly 70 year old conflict, which always had the possibility of devolving into a nuclear conflagration, could soon be a thing of the past.

A critical conversation can solve the most intractable of problems, if one carries them out the right way. This is true between nations, within an organization, in our families, our neighborhoods and wherever else there are people who have disagreements.

Having disagreements is not unusual, but solving them requires immense skill. The ability to conduct a critical conversation forms the most significant component.

Let me give you an example of how conducting a critical conversation can save the direst of days. Alexander the Great invaded India in 326 BC. Among the principal battles he had was with a frontier king of India by the name of Porus.

Now Alexander had already subdued Persia and Egypt when he reached Indian borders and his reputation had preceded him. But Porus was unfazed, as he felt that his large army and war elephants would prevail against the invading armies of Alexander.

However, despite fighting very bravely, Porus lost the battle due to a combination of bad luck and clever fighting strategy by Alexander. A defeated Porus was taken to meet Alexander, who asked him a simple question: "How should I treat you?"

Now Porus may have lost the battle, but he was a brave man and had his dignity intact. It must have been terribly difficult for him to answer the question, given Alexander's reputation of being merciless and extremely cruel to his defeated enemies.

However, Porus calmly replied to Alexander, “As one king should treat another.”

Alexander was so impressed by Porus’s courage and fortitude that he returned the latter’s kingdom to him and made an ally out of him. Now it’s possible that Alexander had strategic reasons for behaving the way he did, and it may not have been entirely due to the favorable impression that Porus made on him.

But the fact of the matter is that Porus acquitted himself very well by being emotionally mature at a time when he had to carry out the most crucial conversation of his life. By so doing he saved his own life and that of many of his subjects; he got to keep his kingdom as well.

You can never underestimate the power of a conversation carried out well. In the beginning of the book I had mentioned that most conflicts may start with a battle or a war, but they end with talks, even in the case of a decisive military victory.

A conversation is really the final arbiter of human faith and destiny. Learning to make fine conversation is therefore crucial to help a person, people or nation move towards the achievement of their goals. The greatest people in the world-founders of religions, kings, emperors, statesmen, leaders and others would not have been able to achieve their goals or see the realization of their vision, if they hadn’t spoken about it first.

You follow the road map for carrying out a critical conversation and you will surely go places in life. The power of the spoken word is a very evocative one and can indeed take one towards great success, if not greatness. This is a power for everyone to grasp, as we all know how to speak. All we need to do is to learn to speak well.

Chapter Nine:

From A Diffident To A Skillful Conversationalist

There is a lot of debate about autism in society. Autistic children are socially maladjusted, often learn to speak very late in life and are anything but skilled conversationalists. If anything they are the very antithesis of skillful conversationalists.

Yet we know of so many examples of autistic children who grew up to be super achievers and brilliant communicators. Who would call Bill Gates, Richard Branson, Tom Cruise, Stanley Kubrick, Lewis Carol and a host of other greats as anything but brilliant? Yet, they all have an autistic or dyslexic past.

If one can reach from a condition of a disability to a place where you are heralded a genius, there has to be something said about how far a person can transform his or her personality. So it figures that a diffident, shy and reticent conversationalist can actually become a Ted speaker (as indeed many have).

The thing about human beings and their mind is the fact that these are extremely malleable, which opens up the possibility of changing the very nature of a person's personality.

We see an example of this in the classic movie 'My Fair Lady' where the erudite Prof. Higgins manages to turn flower girl Eliza Doolittle into a high-class English lady. But is that sort of transformation possible in real life? Yes, indeed it is.

As with most things about humans, the transformation begins in the mind. It is said that the difference between someone who can run a marathon and someone who cannot is in the mind and not the body.

The body will faithfully carryout the instructions of the mind. It is the latter that has to decide whether the marathon can be run or not. Talking about

running, there are those people who would run towards a microphone and those who would run away from a microphone when it comes to public speaking.

The thing about speaking to people, especially people you don't know, makes one nervous. That is a perfectly normal human reaction. People, who don't seem to be nervous when talking with a room full of strangers, are either feeling some nervousness themselves, which they have effectively masked, or they have overcome this kind of nervousness with practice.

You have got to remember that public speaking is not really much of an inborn talent, as it is a well-honed skill. Of course, one's personality has a bearing on this as well.

Introverts generally tend to be happier with their thoughts and don't find going out there and making a conversation very stimulating. In the case of the extrovert, conversing with others is what makes them go.

That being said, the ability to converse well stands one in very good stead and there are often times, when one's very future depends upon how well one speaks.

A job interview or proposing marriage to a partner requires that you speak. So do innumerable other important occasions. You have to be terribly immature as a person to imagine that you can forever get away with not speaking.

Now the question arises how do you master the art of effective speaking, when you are such a shy and introverted person?

Being Nervous is Okay

Well for starters you have to not be ashamed or embarrassed about the fact that you find speaking with others difficult. Lots of people don't - that's your personality and part of who you are and there is no reason to be apologetic about it.

But at the same time, you need to know that your nervousness and diffidence can't be a permanent barrier to your being able to speak publically.

Focus on Your Target Audience

Now target audience is a very marketing like word to use, but it will do for our purpose. Instead of worrying yourself sick about how you would fare in your conversation or talk with a person or people, you would be better off, trying to understand what your target audience expect from you as a speaker.

Once you do that, you will feel some of your nervousness ebb, as you would have got down to trying to understand the business at hand.

Prep Up

If you are going to have an important conversation or you are planning to address an audience, it makes sense to put some preparation into what you are going to say. This may not be true of dyed in the wool conversationalists, but it is certainly true in the case of those who are trying to find their feet.

Think of the things you might want to say to make the discussion interesting and lively. You might even want to conduct a few mock sessions with your friends and family members.

Whatever you say has to be able to catch the attention of your target audience in an effective way, so as to take you closer to achieving the purpose behind the conversation to start with.

If you enter the dialogue with some preparation, you will feel confident about voicing your own opinions at the right time.

Don't Forget To Listen

In all your focus on preparing yourself to talk to your target audience, you shouldn't forget to listen to what the other person is saying. In fact, it makes a lot of sense to speak only after you have heard what the other person said, so that you are in sync with their thought process.

By showing them that you value what they have to say will help you establish a connection with them, which in turn will help you overcome your won reticence and speak with more confidence when you do.

Make Eye Contact

Making eye contact when speaking with someone shows that you are leveling with them, while averting people's gaze when talking to them conveys that you are a shifty person. If you are a shy person you may find it a trifle difficult to begin with, but if you persist you will soon get the hang of it.

When you make eye contact with people, you look confident and in charge and this makes the people you are conversing with respond positively to your body language.

Don't Be Anybody Else

It is all very well to put up a confident façade even if you are jelly inside, but it's not okay to project a persona that's not you. A fake is found out and that will not make a very pretty picture.

So be confident, but be yourself, if you want the person you are talking to take you seriously. Being yourself, in any case, will make you appear more natural and appealing than trying to ape somebody you are not.

Look for Cues

As your conversation skills improve with practice, you will be able to incorporate nuances that will help convert you from a diffident speaker to a great one. They are able to pick up verbal and visual clues which they then proceed to use to their own advantage.

This lets them understand where the other person is coming from and what their motivations may be and mold one's conversation in a manner that tries to address what's important to them.

This would make them seem more trusting of you, thereby taking your conversation to a whole new level.

Be Well Read

If you are shy and not sure of yourself because you feel that you have nothing to contribute to a conversation, you can change that. By reading

and getting to know lots of interesting facts which you can weave into your conversations to make them more interesting.

Besides, reading genuinely broadens your horizon and has the potential of transforming your personality.

Good Conversationalists Are Not Obsessed With Details

It is not important to be able to rattle off facts and figures for you to make a formidable impression as a speaker. You will make a connection if you are genuine and have something genuinely interesting to catch people's attention.

It is you they want to connect with and not the facts and figures that you have so assiduously remembered.

So, if you have been hesitant to speak with people because you don't remember reams of information or do not have a head for figures, you really don't need to worry yourself sick at all. People will like you for what you bring to the table. It is you who can interest them, not clever bits of data and information you can throw at them. If anything that will only turn them away from you.

Be Interested in Other People

The thing about not being able to converse freely with other people is that you are likely too caught up in your own world. That makes you a one-dimensional person. Life is so much fuller if you become interested in other people's worlds.

It is akin to reading a book or watching a movie. Observe people and you will realize that they may have fascinating tales to tell. Once you get genuinely interested in people, your defenses would by and by come down and you will be able to make free and frank conversations.

Often introverts like nothing better than reading a book or watching a movie, as they too have a need to receive newer information. The disadvantage in this kind of information processing is the fact that it is not interactive, as you cannot provide your feedback.

Once an introverted person realizes that a conversation is nothing more than an enhanced way of obtaining new information, they will start enjoying the process and look forward to having interesting conversation with people.

Having a conversation comes naturally to people. Reading does not. Ask a small child if he or she would like to read a book or have someone tell them a story, the chances are that they will choose the latter.

Have Positive Conversations

Learning to become a consummate conversationalist has its stages. If you are a diffident one to start with, you need to up your comfort level before you can really tackle the tough and difficult talks.

So, it makes sense to initially have chats about positive topics so that there is no scope for experiencing stress. Let the conversations be largely about empathy, solutions and all things positive.

Once you become pretty adept at those kinds of dialogues, you can start looking at more challenging ones.

Remember it's a Conversation Not an Argument

A lot of people abjure talks because they feel that these inevitably lead to unpleasantness. This possibly happens because they use an argumentative approach to their conversations.

You have got to remember that a dialogue is different from an argument. An argument is all about disagreeing, whereas a conversation is about a free and fair exchange of ideas.

This is something you have got to understand pretty early if you want to become a great conversationalist. You have got to understand that a conversation is not a contest where there are no prisoners taken. It is rather an exchange of ideas and information and trying to find common ground.

Learn to Respect

The basic ground rule for a successful conversation is respect and to not criticize and judge. If you do the latter your conversation will descend into

an argument or spat.

The idea behind a conversation is not to impose yourself on another person. Just as you have the right to your opinions, so does the other person. If you are not clear about this fact you will never make a great conversationalist.

Try and Make the Other Person Look Good

Remember that when you are speaking with others, their primary concern is they themselves and not you. So if you are able to make them look good or feel good about themselves, you are off to a good start to your dialogue.

Say you have a meeting with a client in another town. If you start your conversation with something like, "I always like coming to your town," you are already off to a good start.

Making the other person look good is a surefire way of smoothening an exchange of words, irrespective of who you are having it with - your peers, subordinates, colleagues, or neighbors.

Recognize the Differences, Accentuate Commonalities

No two people are completely alike. Not even twins. So, it is highly unlikely that you will find everything about the people you deal with agreeable.

You may dislike their clothes, their sense of humor and so many other things. But there would be aspects of their personality that you would find good or at least useful, or why would you be talking to them at all.

Dwell on the commonalities, rather than the point of differences to have successful conversations with people. If you have an ace member of your team who brings in the most revenue, you are not going to start ticking that person off because he or she has high pitched voice.

On the other hand, you are in fact going to put the fact that you find that person's voice irritating at the back of your mind and proceed to have the warmest conversation with the person in order to keep him or her motivated to keep up the good work.

Learn to Ask the Right Questions

Learning to ask the right questions at the right time makes a conversation sparkle. You can ask a question to indicate to the other person that you value their opinion.

Alternatively, you could politely ask a question to fill in your information gap and thereby make your conversation go smoother and become more purposeful. What you should not do is ask questions in an inquisitorial or demanding tone that causes offence.

Use questions as grease to lubricate your conversation and not derail it. Ask the right kind, the right number and right type of questions at the right time.

Give People the Benefit of The Doubt

Human beings are amazingly complex and every once in a while they say something that appears totally bizarre and odd. Chances are they might even say something annoying or even offensive.

Learn to give people the benefit of the doubt for the odd odd statement! There are good chances that it was made inadvertently or on account of a momentary lapse of judgment. It could also be on account of something going on in that person's life.

You can give people some allowance for being human, the same courtesy you would expect for yourself. If you take offence at the slightest slight you are going to lose sight of the bigger picture.

All the same, you should certainly not accept a pattern of bad behavior from anyone for the sake of having a conversation. There is a difference between making an allowance for an occasional lapse and accepting abuse.

Chapter Ten:

Real Life Examples Of Great Emotional Intelligence

Perhaps the greatest crucible for learning to develop and practically deploy emotional intelligence. Like it or not, the workplace can be an emotionally bruising place where despite the formalized structure of hierarchy and pretty explicit delineation of one's key responsibility areas (KRAs), there is an inherent power struggle that one faces day in day out.

That is because the workplace rewards achievers and is the playfield for the game of ambition played out amongst competing employees. Not a very fertile ground to hone your emotional skills in a place where neither a quarter is given or expected.

Yet, this is precisely the place where your emotional intelligence can pay you high dividends. Let us look at a few real life examples.

Who doesn't know about Amazon and its founder Jeff Bezos, who in practically no time at all, judging by the humongous scale of his achievement, created the second most valuable company in the world? That is a most amazing achievement by any standards, the likes of which the world has ever seen.

However, that hasn't stopped the company being at the receiving end of some withering criticism. In 2015 Amazon was ranked 464 out of all the Fortune 500 companies by Payscale when it came to employee turnover. The average employee turnover was a year, which really wasn't bad considering the pace at which Amazon was hiring people.

That fact notwithstanding, this was some putdown indeed for a company of Amazon's stature. Apparently it was felt that Amazon fulfillment centers didn't boast of ideal working conditions.

Now to expect someone in Bezos' position to fly off the handle was not totally unexpected, considering how unjust the allegation was. But he

handled it with tact and emotional maturity, as this statement by him shows:

“Callous management practices don't describe the Amazon I know or the caring Amazonians I work with every day. But if you know of any stories like those reported, I want you to escalate it to HR. You can also email me directly at jeff@amazon.com. Even if it's rare or isolated, our tolerance for any such lack of empathy needs to be zero.”

His statement showed a mature man in control of his emotions and confident of his company's above board record. He also seemed empathetic committed to his employees' welfare.

Then there is the case of Ursula Burns who not only became the first woman CEO to succeed another woman CEO when she took charge of Xerox and guided it through some of its most financially troubled times.

She however had to overcome a grievous shortcoming along the way: Her apparent lack of emotional intelligence. She was unable to hide or disguise her emotions from all and sundry and that can be terribly demotivating from the employees' point of view if they get the wrong end of the stick.

But Burns made a conscious effort to overcome this major shortcoming and her success in doing so got reflected in the way she ran the company.

People like Gandhi and Mandela spent long years in prison fighting for the freedom of their respective nations from colonial rule. It must have been emotionally tough for the two great leaders to have kept the faith during their long prison sentences, but they were made of sterner stuff and never lost sight of the bigger picture-through all their trials and tribulations.

Winston Churchill was as flawed a man as any and lived with many insecurities. However, his finest hour came during the Second World War when he saw Britain reverse its fortune and emerge victorious. His life's experiences had provided him with the emotional intelligence and self-belief to take some very difficult but correct decisions.

Churchill's speech during his nation's hour of crisis when he exhorted his countrymen to fight the enemy bravely shows ample glimpses of the steel within the man-

“Turning once again, and this time more generally, to the question of invasion, I would observe that there has never been a period in all these long centuries of which we boast when an absolute guarantee against invasion, still less against serious raids, could have been given to our people. In the days of Napoleon, of which I was speaking just now, the same wind which would have carried his transports across the Channel might have driven away the blockading fleet. There was always the chance, and it is that chance which has excited and befooled the imaginations of many Continental tyrants. Many are the tales that are told. We are assured that novel methods will be adopted, and when we see the originality of malice, the ingenuity of aggression, which our enemy displays, we may certainly prepare ourselves for every kind of novel stratagem and every kind of brutal and treacherous maneuver. I think that no idea is so outlandish that it should not be considered and viewed with a searching, but at the same time, I hope, with a steady eye. We must never forget the solid assurances of sea power and those which belong to air power if it can be locally exercised.

I have, myself, full confidence that if all do their duty, if nothing is neglected, and if the best arrangements are made, as they are being made, we shall prove ourselves once more able to defend our island home, to ride out the storm of war, and to outlive the menace of tyranny, if necessary for years, if necessary alone. At any rate, that is what we are going to try to do. That is the resolve of His Majesty's Government – every man of them. That is the will of Parliament and the nation. The British Empire and the French Republic, linked together in their cause and in their need, will defend to the death their native soil, aiding each other like good comrades to the utmost of their strength.

Even though large tracts of Europe and many old and famous States have fallen or may fall into the grip of the Gestapo and all the odious apparatus of Nazi rule, we shall not flag or fail. We shall go on to the end. We shall fight in France, we shall fight on the seas and oceans, we shall fight with growing confidence and growing strength in the air, we shall defend our island, whatever the cost may be. We shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight in the fields and in the streets, we shall fight in the hills; we shall never surrender, and if, which I do not for a moment believe, this island or a large part of it were subjugated and

starving, then our Empire beyond the seas, armed and guarded by the British Fleet, would carry on the struggle, until, in God's good time, the New World, with all its power and might, steps forth to the rescue and the liberation of the old.”

One of the best examples of a leader with a highly developed emotional intelligence was none other than Abraham Lincoln, in an era, when nobody knew what emotional maturity meant. He carried out seismic changes guided solely by his inner convictions.

Everything he did, in the face of fierce opposition, was indicative of an emotionally intelligent person—abolishing slavery, and not meting out punishment to the defeated Confederacy were the prime examples of this.

Read the speech that he delivered in 1863 on the battlefield and you will know that this is man with a sense of mission and purpose speaking:

“Fourscore and seven years ago our fathers brought forth, on this continent, a new nation, conceived in liberty, and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal. Now we are engaged in a great civil war, testing whether that nation, or any nation so conceived, and so dedicated, can long endure. We are met on a great battle-field of that war. We have come to dedicate a portion of that field, as a final resting-place for those who here gave their lives, that that nation might live. It is altogether fitting and proper that we should do this. But, in a larger sense, we cannot dedicate, we cannot consecrate—we cannot hallow—this ground. The brave men, living and dead, who struggled here, have consecrated it far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note, nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here. It is for us the living, rather, to be dedicated here to the unfinished work which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced. It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us—that from these honored dead we take increased devotion to that cause for which they here gave the last full measure of devotion—that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain—that this nation, under God, shall have a new birth of freedom, and that government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth.”

Conclusion

The world today is more fast-paced than it ever has been. Our personal and work lives are increasingly turbulent and we are constantly on the lookout for ways and means to achieve our objectives.

In times such as this, leveraging emotional intelligence is what will give you a head start and take you that much closer to your objectives. The four important components of emotional intelligence that can help you come close to realizing your full potential are the ability to be self-aware, the ability to manage your emotions, the ability to be socially aware and empathetic and the ability to manage relationships.

What we have to learn to live with is the fact that we have to learn to control our emotions on a daily basis on account of the fact our brains are programmed to let emotions hold sway over calm reasoning. The rational portion of your brain can't really subsume the emotions felt in the limbic system.

Learning to control surging emotions takes time and practice, but it can be done and it should be done. Difficult as it may be, the payoff in terms of the success we achieve on its account is well worth it.

What is important to remember though is that your emotional intelligence skills need to be honed constantly as not doing so may make your skills rusty. While you might get better at managing emotions with age and experience, your emotions will never quite go away.

So, you have got to be on guard to ensure that your ability to control these emotions does not diminish. The digital era is a time of relentless change and people and organizations are finding it increasingly difficult to deal with the sheer magnitude of the change as people's emotions tend to set up roadblocks.

The importance of emotional intelligence has increased manifold on account of its ability to let people communicate better, which is the need of the times. With digital means of communiqué enhancing the geographical footprint of businesses people often need to communicate across nations.

This again throws up challenges in the shape of cultural and linguistic differences between people. One's emotional intelligence is something that acts as a life saver in such situations.

An emotionally intelligent person will be able to actively listen and understand what the other person is saying. This ability to be empathetic will enable them to communicate across the boundaries of time, distance and nationality as is often the case these days.

The ability to be in the know of one's own emotions and those of the others is something that the corporate organizations around the world value a great deal. This is because emotional intelligence has a direct bearing to one being able to extract the best from people and this has a direct impact on the performance of a company.

Therefore, it's not just your skills, academic and professional qualifications and your work experience that you bring to the table that are enough for you to succeed in today's times. It's also your emotional intelligence.

This is the reason why schools these days have taken to administering EQ tests to understand how children fare in this vital aspect of human behavior. Perhaps the greatest impact of being able to understand and manage your emotions lies in how you are able to carry out your critical conversations.

Emotional intelligence is an effective tool in achieving the ability to converse well because it allows an individual to leverage his or her emotions to work in his or her favor. This is managed with the help of self-awareness and the ability to use one's emotions to further one's cause. Such people have the ability to motivate themselves, keep their impulses in check and eschew instant gratification in favor of achievement of the greater goal.

They will therefore be able to conduct, goal focused and nuanced conversations, as they realize what is at stake. Emotional intelligence allows an individual to build social intelligence, enabling a person to be able to presciently understand another person's perspective. Such an emotionally aware individual will not be fazed by conflict, but view it as an opportunity to resolve it.

The best way to approach a crucial conversation is bringing it out into the open along with all the relevant information pertaining to the issue at hand. The information needs to flow from both the participants (or more if there are more).

That will likely facilitate a useful dialog like nothing else will. A dialog helps because it helps you find common ground with others, ultimately leading to synergy.

Of course for you to carry out a successful critical conversation you need to know what you want first. You should also possess the dexterity to retrieve a situation if the dialog doesn't seem to be happening right.

The only way that you can possibly do that is by focusing on the bigger picture, even while you weave an alternate narrative. You need to not forget what you wanted from the conversation in the first place, while being flexible enough to make the necessary adjustments and compromises. You can't sit on a high horse and get into an either or situation.

The thing about using emotional intelligence in critical conversations is the fact that you need to control your emotions, lest they control you. The second thing to understand is that emotions don't happen in a vacuum. They are caused.

Lastly, you have got to be able to bridge the gap between your feelings and those of the others by pitching your own story to add value to the conversation. If you want to see how you might ace crucial conversation you might want to listen to Ted Talks by Kelly McGonigal (How to make stress your friend), Arianna Huffington (How to succeed? Get more sleep), Laura Trice (The Power of Saying Thank You), Daniel Goleman (Why Aren't We More Compassionate?) and Mandy Len Catron (Falling in love in the easy part).

Exercises That Help Enhance Emotional Intelligence

You have read at many places in this book that emotional intelligence is something you can work at building up. It was also mentioned that this is a skill that needs constant practice or you risk losing it. Let's learn to undertake certain exercises that will help us do just that.

- Exercises to Enhance Self Awareness

What's Your Motivation?

Study the things that you do and try to understand your motivation behind doing those things. Ask yourself if you are doing it for yourself or for someone else?

Do remember to ask yourself if you were right in prioritizing the things you are currently doing over things that you have slated for later. Better still write down the things that you are currently doing. This will give you a handle on what is really top priority for you.

Understand Your Value System

If the things that you are currently doing do not align with your value system, you surely have a warped sense of priorities that is harmful to your own self-interest.

You have got to course correct and reprioritize if you find that you spend most of the time doing things that are not in sync with your priorities.

Understand Your Current Feelings

You really should take some time out and analyze your feelings at the current moment. Maybe you could put down your feelings on a piece of paper or type them on to a device.

Whatever be the current state of your emotion, it helps to put it down. Now try and describe your emotion with an example like happy like a baby or

angry as a bull.

Make a List of Your Emotions on a Daily Basis

Up the scale and start listing all the emotions you feel during the course of a day. At the end of the day match the number of positive emotions that you felt with the number of negative emotions that you felt.

Try to identify the dominant emotions and their triggers. This will empower you to work in eradicating the very source of negative emotions.

Exercises to Improve Self- Management

- **Breathing**

We have all become so busy with our daily lives that we literally have very little time to breathe. This is a pity because nothing dissipates stress more than a deep breath or two.

You may want to check this out the next time you start imagining stress. The best way to do this is to close your eyes and take a few deep breaths. This will prevent you from immediately reacting to a situation and taking a step that you might regret.

You will be in a much better state to take a considered decision after you have cooled down. Using your very own breath to manage your own emotions is an ancient technique which forms the basis of Yogic meditation, a known stress buster.

Counting

This is a corollary of the above point. As you breathe deeply to dissipate stress, make it a point to slowly count till 10. You could silently say each number after a long breath.

This will give you the time to think through your emotions and respond calmly rather than go all furs blazing.

Dedicating Some Time to the Problem

Setting aside some time to solve a knotty problem is the best way to get rid of it. You can't do it in the midst of things that you do routinely. Say your neighbor has a nasty habit of making his dog urinate against your wall, and you have had enough of it and want to talk to your neighbor about this disgusting habit of his.

Now you can't make a call to him from office, when your mind is preoccupied with a thousand things. It is far better that you walk across to his house on the weekend and talk the thing over with him.

If you have a whole slew of knotty problems you could designate fifteen to twenty minutes a day to attend to them. This will give you the focus to be able to deal with these effectively.

Exercises to Enhance Social Awareness

- **Living for Now**

The biggest malaise of the digital era is the fact that none of us live for the moment. We have to multitask like crazy. If we are eating out at a restaurant, we need to take a picture of our food and post it on social media, before we get down to the business of actually eating and relishing the food.

When we are in a meeting, only a part of us listens, the other part is scanning mails on our smart phone. That is not what we are meant to do with our time on earth. We need to savor every minute that we get on this beautiful planet. That is what will set us free to live our life to the fullest. Realizing this is all about being emotionally mature.

Practice living fully in the present and being fully immersed and focused on the task at hand. This will help you be empathetic towards others and thereby improve the quality of your interactions.

Go Out and Stroll

We need to move away from our ensconced life and connect with the world around us - smell the roses, so to speak. Take a walk near your office or home. Observe the surroundings and see what the people are up to.

Even inside the office stroll around the place. See what everyone's up to. Talk to your colleagues. Find out what's up with them-personally and professionally. You can surely spend some fifteen minutes doing so, every day. This will help you forge connection, besides broadening your horizon.

Observe People

Whenever you are with people or among people, watch them and observe them carefully. Look at the way they interact with each other, what emotions they display, the kind of expression they wear, their body language and anything else you can pick up. You do this regularly enough and willy nilly you will empathy skill will get enhanced.

Exercises to Enhance Relationship Management

- **The Little Things Matter**

The small things in life really matter when it comes to forging lasting relationships with people. A thank you, sorry and please are the kind of things that are both easy to say and carry a weight of meaning in that it shows that you value the relationship with the person in question. Furthermore, call them by their name when you can - nothing sounds sweeter to somebody than hearing their name being called out.

Express Your Positive Emotions towards People

If you like something about somebody, let them know. Otherwise they will never come to know, and you would have lost a potential ally.

One of the biggest mistakes we make in life is to assume people know what you think about them. They don't because they are not mind readers. Show people you appreciate them by praising them to their face or obliquely by sending them cards and gifts.

Explain Why You Made a Decision

Very often, you make a decision on behalf of others that you think is in their best interest. It is all very well if the others agree. But, what if they don't? That's how conflict arises. That is why it makes sense for you to communicate why you took a certain decision. This is equally true in a corporate as well as personal scenario.

Your not communicating why a decision that impacts somebody directly shows the height of insensitivity and emotional immaturity. It doesn't matter how old you are, how highly qualified and what your designation is.

If you are not divulging vital information to those that it directly impacts, you are being emotionally inadequate. This has been particularly true of doctors in the past who would more often than not be uncommunicative with paying patients about decisions that impacted their very lives in the most profound manner.

This is something that medical schools are now addressing by way of making changes to course curricula. Doctors are now given lessons in empathy.

Not Shirking Tough Conversations

Emotionally immature people like to put off tough decisions because they want to avoid possible unpleasantness. The fact is that most people would rather avoid unpleasant circumstances than face them, but an emotionally mature person will not shirk having a tough decision if that is in their best interest.

One can of course make an attempt to make the conversations as amiable as possible. It's best to begin with what one agrees upon and see if sort of a rapport can be built. One can further make an effort to understand the other's point of view with empathy.

Sure, one will be tempted to interject, but one should resist that temptation. Once the other person is through you can let them know where you are coming from and what your pain points are. All the time it is important to not lose sight of the common ground that you have found and build on that.

Having this type of an inclusive discussion should make it a lot easier to have that tough conversation that you were trying to avoid.